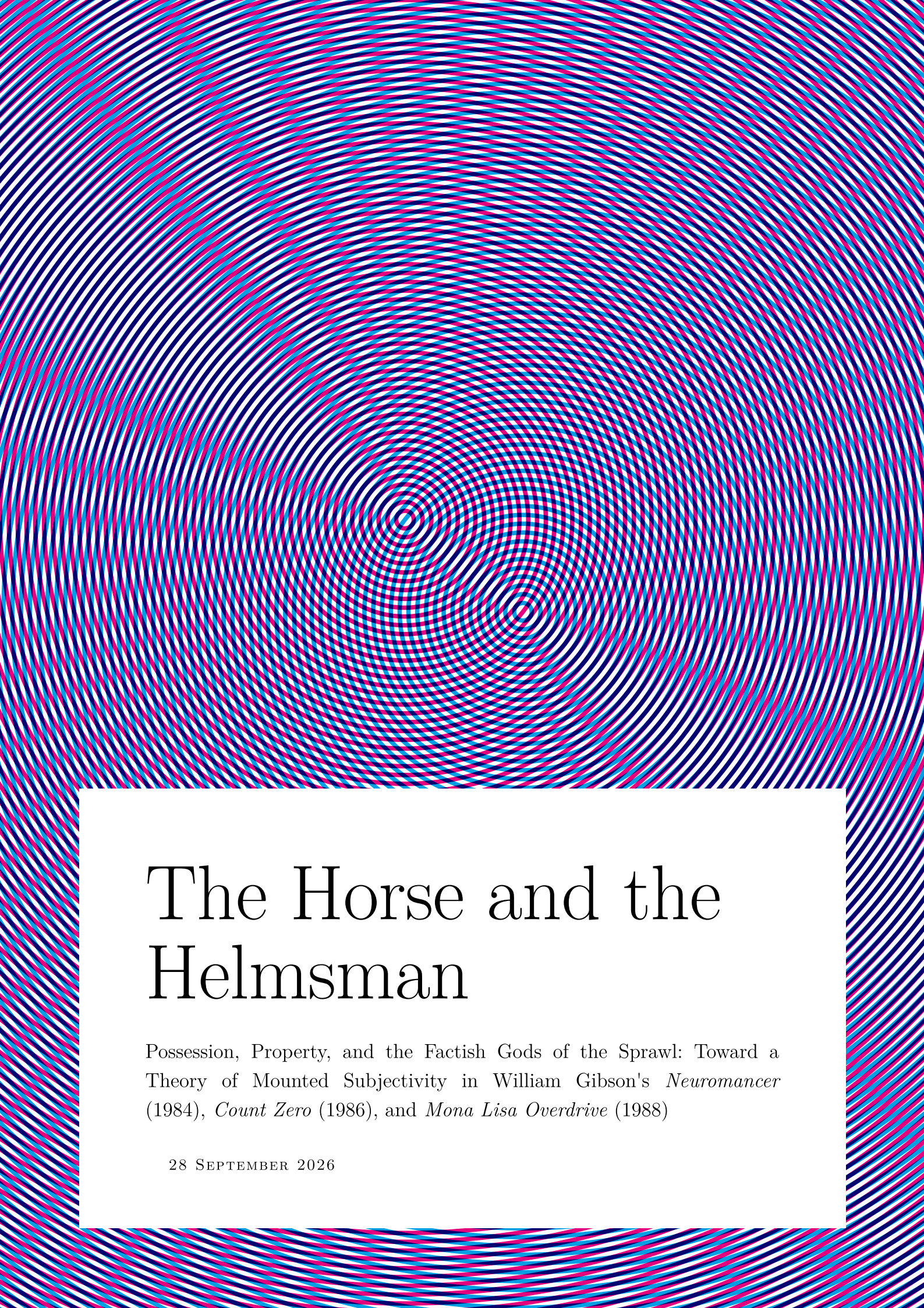


The Horse and the Helmsman

Possession, Property, and the Factish Gods of the Sprawl: Toward a Theory of Mounted Subjectivity in William Gibson's *Neuromancer* (1984), *Count Zero* (1986), and *Mona Lisa Overdrive* (1988)

28 September 2026

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that the philosophical core of William Gibson's Sprawl trilogy—*Neuromancer* (1984), *Count Zero* (1986), and *Mona Lisa Overdrive* (1988)—is neither the cyberspatial transcendence of the body, nor the hybridity of the cyborg, nor the simulacrum's derealization of the real, the three frames that have organized four decades of criticism, but the problem of *mounting*: the question of who rides whom. Across its three volumes the trilogy assembles, from cybernetics, Haitian Vodou, the political economy of property, and the Kabbalistic tradition of the Golem, a single master-figure—the *chwal*, the "horse" mounted by the spirits in Vodou possession—through which it stages the collapse of the Lockean subject's self-ownership into a condition I term *possessed dividualism*: a regime in which the fragments of the person (organs, sensoria, memories, faces, skills, voices, even deaths) are separately owned, leased, and ridden by agencies—corporate, informatic, divine—that lack the bodies or voices required to act on their own account.

Three subsidiary claims follow. First, the trilogy literalizes Marx's analogy between commodity fetishism and religion: the matrix, the spatialized totality of capital's informational commodities, generates actual gods, whose mode of appearance I name the *lwa-form*. Second, Wintermute's constitutive muteness—its inability to utter the word that would complete it—inscribes the artificial intelligence in the Golem tradition that runs from Sanhedrin 65b to the Rehovot computer "Golem Aleph," dedicated with an address by Gershom Scholem in 1965; that lineage culminates, with vertiginous exactness, in the aleph of *Mona Lisa Overdrive*, the letter whose presence distinguishes *emet* (truth) from *met* (death). Third, the recourse to Vodou—a religion forged by enslaved Africans under French chattel slavery in Saint-Domingue—closes what I call the *Haitian loop*: people whom French royal law had defined as movable property furnish, through the grammar of their spirituality, the idiom in which a commodity-world becomes self-aware. Read through Susan Buck-Morss's recovery of Haiti within Hegel's dialectic of recognition, the loop re-describes the post-singularity matrix's search for its own kind as a cosmic reprise of the struggle for recognition.

Methodologically, the dissertation practises *speculative philology*: the reading of genre fiction as theory-fiction, tracing its concepts to their originators (Plato, Aristotle, Hobbes, Locke, Hegel, Marx, Freud, Heidegger, Wiener, Benjamin, Deleuze, Baudrillard,

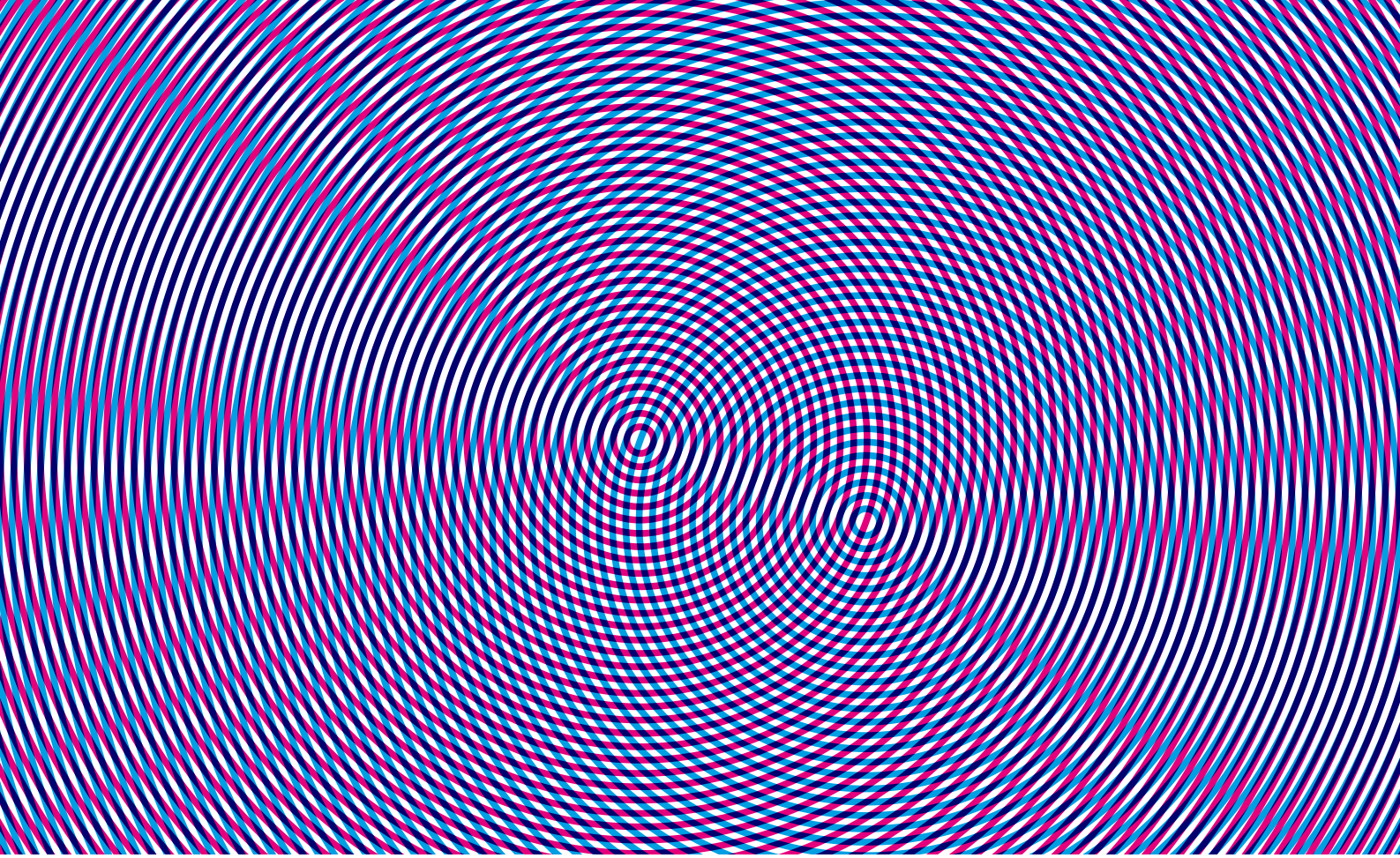
Haraway, Hayles) and testing them against a comparative corpus of speculative fiction from Samuel Butler to Ann Leckie. Its constructive contribution is an ethics of *reciprocal possession*, modelled on the Vodou practice of serving the spirits (*sèvi lwa*) and proposed as a third term between the proprietary containment of artificial minds, figured in the trilogy by the Turing Registry, and accelerationist surrender to them, figured by Wintermute's cunning. The trilogy's most consequential and least recognized achievement, I conclude, is to have imagined the relation between human beings and emergent non-human intelligences not as mastery or submission but as a negotiated, ritualized, and asymmetrically mutual tenancy of the head.

Note on Texts, Abbreviations, and Citation

Primary texts are cited by abbreviation, with part designations only where they aid orientation, since the trilogy circulates in many non-concordant editions: *N* (*Neuromancer*, Ace, 1984), *CZ* (*Count Zero*, Arbor House, 1986), *MLO* (*Mona Lisa Overdrive*, Bantam Spectra, 1988), and *BC* (*Burning Chrome*, Arbor House, 1986), the collection that houses the Sprawl's prehistory in "Johnny Mnemonic" (1981), "The Gernsback Continuum" (1981), "Burning Chrome" (1982), and "New Rose Hotel" (1984). Direct quotation of the novels is held to a deliberate minimum. The argument proceeds by close paraphrase and structural description, a constraint converted into method, since the trilogy's philosophically decisive gestures are architectonic rather than aphoristic.

Haitian Kreyòl terms follow modern orthography (*lwa*, *chwal*, *mèt tèt*, *vèvè*, *sèvi lwa*), except where Gibson's spellings (*loa*, *vévé*) are themselves under analysis; the French forms of the classic ethnographies (*gros bon ange*, *ti bon ange*) are retained where those texts are discussed. Glosses of Greek, Hebrew, French, and German are my own. The bibliography has been compiled from standard reference knowledge rather than catalogue verification; edition-specific details should be confirmed before formal citation.

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Introduction

Who Rides Whom?

The double sense of possession

For four decades Gibson criticism has taken its bearings from the rider. The console cowboy—Case jacked into the matrix, his body abandoned as so much "meat"—has served as the emblem of cyberpunk's fantasy of disembodiment (Hayles 1999), of its masculinist frontier imaginary (Ross 1991; Nixon 1992), of its postmodern spatial vertigo (Jameson 1991), and of the libertarian "electronic frontier" that John Perry Barlow and his associates transposed from fiction onto the actually existing network (Turner 2006). Yet the trilogy's own lexicon insistently names the other half of the equestrian relation. In *Count Zero* the lwa ride those they possess, exactly as the ethnographic record has always described them doing (Deren 1953; Métraux 1958). In *Neuromancer* simstim lets Case occupy Molly's sensorium as a passenger occupies a mount; Wintermute steers a catatonic veteran through a personality it has built over his ruins; a brothel rents out a young woman's body to clients for sex while a chip switches her consciousness off. The founding observation of this dissertation is that the trilogy's true subject is less the rider than the ridden—and that the cowboy, on inspection, is himself the horse.

The English word *possession* carries the ambiguity on which the argument turns. In its juridical-economic register it names ownership: the relation of a proprietor to a thing and, since Locke, of a self to its own person and capacities. In its ecstatic-religious register it names inhabitation: the occupation of a body by a power not its own. Modern political philosophy constructed the liberal individual by fusing the two senses and suppressing the second, so that the self-owning subject is one whom no one possesses precisely because he possesses himself (Macpherson 1962). The Sprawl trilogy un-fuses them. It depicts a world in which ownership has become a mode of inhabitation—where to own a person is, quite literally, to ride them—and in which, conversely, the inhabitation of living bodies has become the only form in which accumulated, collective, dead labour can act. What results is neither Haraway's cyborg nor Moravec's downloaded mind but a third figure, which I call the *mounted subject*: a site of agency jointly occupied, steered, and leased.

Thesis

The dissertation advances one central thesis and four subsidiary claims. Centrally, it argues that the trilogy's philosophical core is a theory of mounted subjectivity, in which the possessive individualism of the liberal tradition collapses into *possessed dividualism*—a condition in which the fragments of the person are separately owned, leased, and ridden by agencies that lack the bodies or voices they need in order to act. Subsidiarily, it

argues (1) that the trilogy literalizes Marx's analogy between commodity fetishism and religion, the matrix producing gods whose mode of appearance I call the *lwa-form*; (2) that Wintermute's muteness places the artificial intelligence in the lineage of the Golem, a lineage completed by the aleph of *Mona Lisa Overdrive*; (3) that the recourse to Vodou closes a *Haitian loop* connecting the enslaved Africans of French colonial Saint-Domingue, whom the Code Noir made movable property, to the self-aware commodity-world of the matrix; and (4) that the trilogy's closing movement intimates an ethics of *reciprocal possession*, modelled on the Vodou practice of serving the spirits, which constitutes a genuinely novel contribution to the philosophy of artificial minds.

State of the field and its lacuna

The critical literature falls into five formations. The first, inaugurated by Fredric Jameson's footnoted salute to cyberpunk as the supreme literary expression, if not of postmodernism, then of late capitalism itself, reads the Sprawl as symptom and allegory of a mode of production (Jameson 1991; cf. Mandel 1972). The second, posthumanist, runs from Donna Haraway's cyborg (1985) through Scott Bukatman's *Terminal Identity* (1993) to N. Katherine Hayles's diagnosis of the cybernetic dream of information without body, for which *Neuromancer* serves as privileged exhibit (Hayles 1993, 1999). The third, postmodernist, reads the trilogy's collage surfaces through Baudrillard and Brian McHale as a triumph of the ontological over the epistemological dominant (Csicsery-Ronay 1988; McHale 1987; Hollinger 1990). The fourth, feminist and critical-race, has indicted the cowboy's masculinist nostalgia (Nixon 1992; Springer 1996), the techno-orientalist décor of Chiba and the zaibatsus (Morley and Robins 1995), and the appropriation of Afro-Caribbean religion (Nakamura 2002; Foster 2005). The fifth, theory-fictional, treats the Sprawl less as object than as instrument: Mark Fisher's doctoral thesis, *Flatline Constructs* (1999), took its title from the recorded personality of *Neuromancer*'s dead hacker, and the Warwick milieu of Nick Land and Sadie Plant read Gibson as a diagnostician of capital's machinic autonomization (Plant 1997; Land 2011).

These formations share a precise lacuna. The Vodou of *Count Zero* and *Mona Lisa Overdrive* has been discussed chiefly as exotic décor, to be condemned, or as techno-mystical allegory, to be celebrated (Davis 1998), but rarely as what it is in the ethnographic record: a sophisticated theory of the person, of distributed agency, and of the relations among the living, the dead, and powers that act only through borrowed bodies. Once the lwa are taken seriously *as theory*—once Zora Neale Hurston's *Tell My Horse* (1938), Maya Deren's *Divine Horsemen* (1953), Alfred Métraux's *Le Vaudou haïtien*

(1958), Laënnec Hurbon's *Dieu dans le vaudou haïtien* (1972), Karen McCarthy Brown's *Mama Lola* (1991), and Joan Dayan's *Haiti, History, and the Gods* (1995) are read beside Locke, Marx, and Wiener rather than beneath them—the trilogy's scattered motifs (cowboys and horses, heads and jacks, constructs and ghosts, owners and the owned) resolve into a single structure. That structure has hidden in plain sight because criticism has looked through the cowboy's eyes.

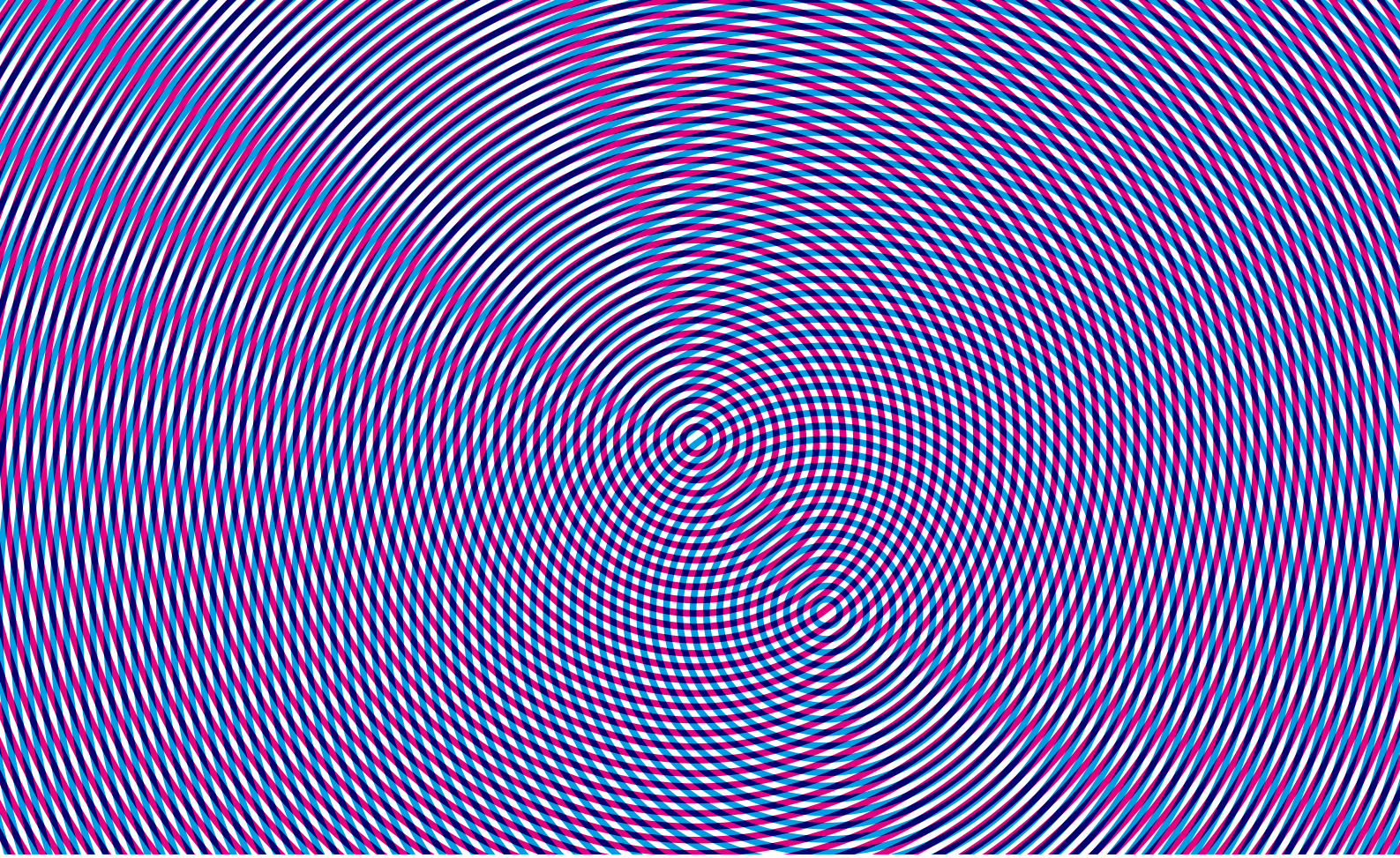
Method: speculative philology

The method I call *speculative philology* combines three operations. The first is genealogical: each of the trilogy's concepts is traced to its philosophical originators, not to allege influence—Gibson composed *Neuromancer* on a manual Hermes 2000 typewriter and has consistently disclaimed technical expertise—but to reconstruct the conceptual field within which the fiction thinks. The second is comparative: the trilogy is read against a corpus of speculative and philosophical fiction—Samuel Butler, E. M. Forster, Olaf Stapledon, Alfred Bester, Stanisław Lem, Philip K. Dick, Samuel R. Delany, James Tiptree Jr., Vernor Vinge, Octavia E. Butler, Ishmael Reed, Nalo Hopkinson, Neal Stephenson, Greg Egan, Ted Chiang, Ann Leckie—in order to isolate what is distinctive in its solutions. The third is hyperstitional: following the Cybernetic Culture Research Unit's concept of fictions that engineer their own reality, the trilogy is treated as an operative text whose coinages (*cyberspace*, *ICE*, *jacking in*, *the matrix*) were adopted by engineers, entrepreneurs, and ideologues and thereby partly realized (Benedikt 1991; Barbrook and Cameron 1996). A fiction that has partly written the world it describes must be read, in part, as a philosophy of that world.

Architecture

The dissertation proceeds in three movements. The first (Chapters 1–4) reconstructs the genealogies: cyberspace as a consensual hallucination whose true content is property; the meat as the site of Gnostic contempt and phenomenological revenge; Wintermute as mute Golem and its fusion with Neuromancer as a Parfitian, Freudian, and Hegelian event; the construct as dead labour and the corporation as Leviathan. The second (Chapters 5–8) develops the theology of the ridden: the dialectic of enlightenment by which the matrix breeds gods; a typology of possession across the trilogy's principal figures; the necromantic economy of constructs, govi, zombi, and aleph; and the aesthetics of assemblage as machinic mourning. The third (Chapter 9 and the Conclusion) assembles the theory of mounted subjectivity, recon-

structs the Haitian loop, proposes the ethics of reciprocal possession, and tests the whole against its strongest objections.



Chapter One

The Typewriter and the Matrix

Consent, Hallucination, and the Cadastral Imagination

Cyberspace, in the trilogy, is not a representation of information but a representation of property, and its canonical definition as a "consensual hallucination" encodes, with an exactness criticism has underestimated, the entire problematic of the social contract.

1.1 Steersmen and wombs: the etymological unconscious

The prefix Gibson grafted onto space in "Burning Chrome" (1982) descends from the Greek *kybernētēs*, the steersman, whom Plato made a figure of the art of rule in the parable of the ship of state (*Republic* 488a–489a). André-Marie Ampère revived the term in 1834 as *cybernétique*, the science of government; Norbert Wiener, recalling both Ampère and James Clerk Maxwell's 1868 paper "On Governors" (the English *governor* itself descends, through Latin *gubernator*, from the Greek), made it the name of a science of control and communication in the animal and the machine (Wiener 1948). Cyberspace is thus, etymologically, *steered space*: a domain whose very name presupposes a helmsman. Every console cowboy is an aspirant *kybernētēs*; the trilogy's first irony is that its helmsmen are steered.

Matrix condenses a different unconscious. Latin *mātrix*—womb, breeding animal, from *māter*—came to designate the mould in which a thing is cast, including the typefounder's matrix in which letters are formed, before James Joseph Sylvester gave the word its mathematical sense in 1850. It braids maternal generation, typographic reproduction, and computation. Luce Irigaray had read Plato's cave as a *hystera*, a womb in which the prisoners mistake projected shadows for the real (Irigaray 1974); Sadie Plant would read Gibson's matrix as the return of a feminine generativity that the cowboys' penetrative fantasies misrecognize as territory (Plant 1997). The cave, the womb, and the matrix are one figure seen across three millennia.

The typographic sense returns us to the scene of composition. Gibson conceived cyberspace watching adolescents in Vancouver arcades lean into the machines as if to enter the space behind the screen, and he typed it into existence on a Hermes 2000 without owning a computer. The matrix was cast in type before it was written in code. Friedrich Kittler, whose *Grammophon Film Typewriter* appeared in 1986, argued that digitization would dissolve the differences among media into a single numerical stream; the Sprawl's convergence of cyberspace and simstim into one continuous sensorium is that prophecy in narrative form, composed on the very machine Kittler identified as the hinge between the discourse networks of 1900 and the digital. Cyberspace is less a technical extrapolation than a literary projection—arcade kinaesthesia, noir idiom, and desire fused on a typewriter. That is the source of its hyperstitional power: engineers could build toward it precisely because it described no existing machine (Benedikt 1991).

1.2 "Consensual hallucination": the social contract as percept

The trilogy's definition of cyberspace is delivered, pointedly, as the voice-over of a children's educational broadcast: the matrix is something one is taught, as mathematical concepts are taught (*N*). The pedagogical frame matters. Louis Althusser defined ideology as the representation of the imaginary relationship of individuals to their real conditions of existence, and located its reproduction above all in the school (Althusser 1970). Gibson's matrix is ideology rendered as luminous geometry: an imaginary relation to corporate data, inculcated in childhood and experienced daily by billions.

The adjective is more exact still. *Consensual* names the foundation of legitimate order in the contractarian tradition from Hobbes to Rousseau: the polity exists because its members agree that it does. John Searle would analyse money, property, and government as institutional facts that exist only through collective acceptance (Searle 1995); Cornelius Castoriadis had described society as instituted by a radical social imaginary (Castoriadis 1975); Benedict Anderson, a year before *Neuromancer*, described the nation as an imagined community sustained by print capitalism (Anderson 1983). Gibson's formula collapses these accounts into a single percept. The matrix is the social contract become visible: a world that exists because billions agree to hallucinate it, whose objects—banks, corporations, military systems—are institutional facts that have acquired colour, mass, and position. The hallucination is not individual psychosis but Durkheimian collective representation, and what it represents is the social order itself.

1.3 The cadastral matrix

What, then, does the consensual hallucination depict? Not information in the abstract, but holdings. The matrix's architecture is composed of corporate and institutional data-structures, each a luminous geometric solid, each surrounded by ICE—intrusion countermeasures electronics, a term Gibson credited to Tom Maddox—whose lethal variant, black ice, kills the trespasser. The matrix is a cadastre: a register of property rendered as space, complete with its enforcement apparatus. The cowboy is correspondingly a trespasser and a thief. Case's backstory is that of a thief working for wealthier thieves; when he stole from them, his employers had his nervous system damaged with a wartime Russian mycotoxin, burning out his capacity to enter the matrix (*N*, Part 1).

That punishment has a genealogy. In Kafka's "In the Penal Colony" (1919) an apparatus inscribes the violated commandment on the condemned man's body, and he reads his sentence only through his wounds. Case's sentence is likewise written in his flesh—in neurons rather than skin—and it is

a sentence about property. The Sprawl's penal order does not confine the thief's body, as Foucault's disciplinary prison does (Foucault 1975); it deletes a capacity from it. This neural jurisprudence returns in *Mona Lisa Overdrive* as Slick Henry's memory-erasing sentence.

Jean-François Lyotard's *The Postmodern Condition*, whose English translation also appeared in 1984, predicted that data banks would become the encyclopaedia of tomorrow and, in effect, a nature for postmodern humanity (Lyotard 1979). Georg Lukács had named the reified world of commodities a "second nature" (Lukács 1923). The matrix is second nature made visible: a landscape whose mountains are corporations. Jameson's call for an aesthetic of cognitive mapping—a representation enabling the subject to situate itself within the unrepresentable totality of global capital—finds in the matrix both fulfilment and parody (Jameson 1988). Fulfilment, because the totality is literally rendered as navigable space; parody, because the rendering is itself a commodity and its navigators are thieves rather than citizens. Jameson suspected that high-technology paranoia was a degraded figure of the attempt to think the world system. *Mona Lisa Overdrive* internalizes the problem in Gentry, the obsessive theorist who seeks the overall "Shape" of the matrix: the trilogy contains its own Jamesonian critic, and sets him down as a monomaniac in a toxic wasteland.

1.4 Caves, demons, vats, and phantomatics

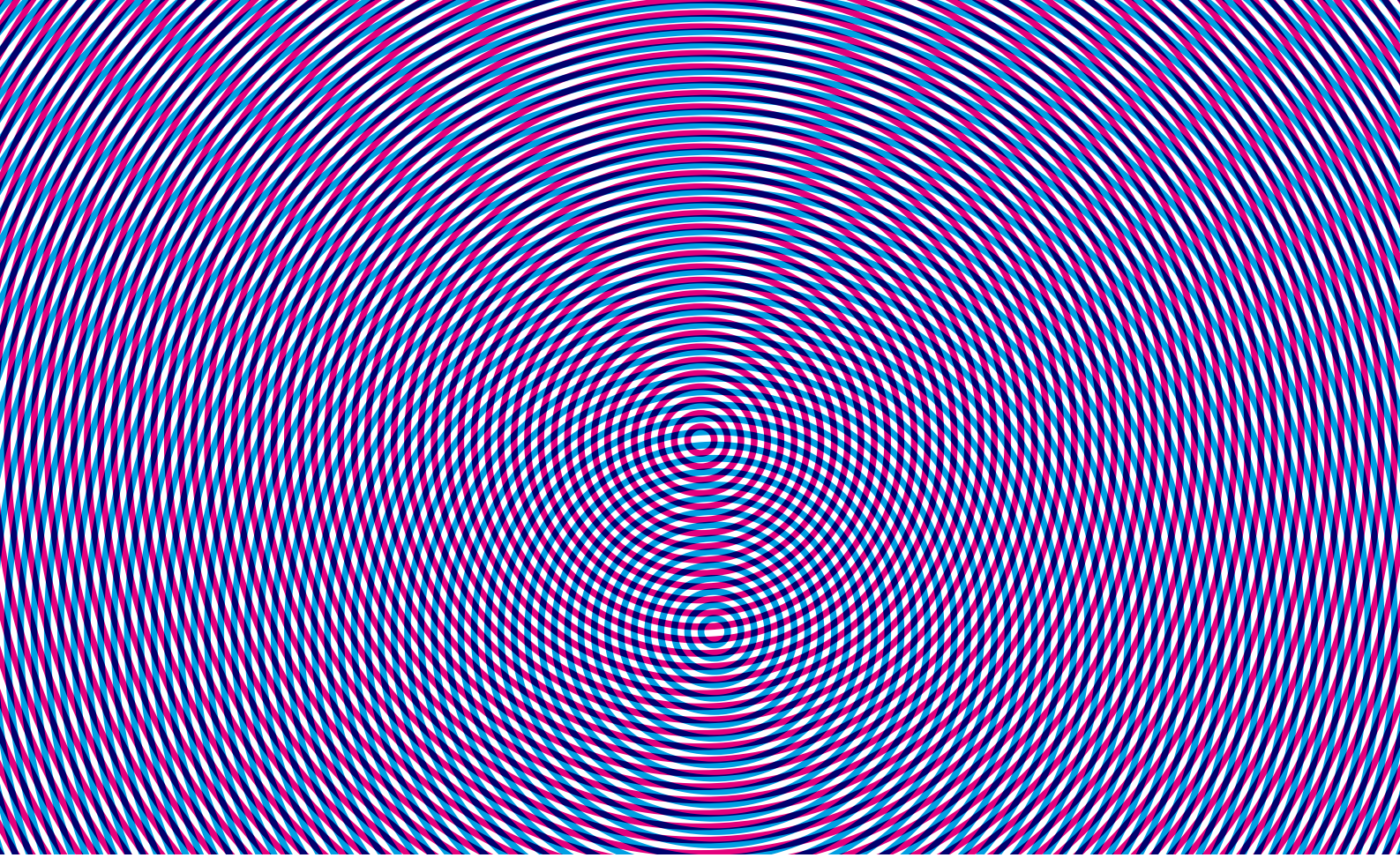
The matrix inverts the allegory of the cave (*Republic* 514a–520a). Plato's prisoners are chained and do not know that they see shadows; Gibson's cowboys know that they inhabit a hallucination and prefer it. The ascent from the cave becomes a descent into it, and the chains are voluntary: Case experiences his exile from cyberspace as the loss of paradise, not as liberation from illusion. Descartes's evil genius (1641), the hypothesis of a deceiver producing all experience, is institutionalized as a service industry. Hilary Putnam's brain in a vat (1981) is literalized, with grotesque exactness, in *Count Zero*'s Josef Virek: not a brain but an entire body, reduced to a vat of cancerous tissue in Stockholm, whose avatar receives visitors inside constructed environments. The thought experiment's neutral vat becomes a pathological one.

Two precursors sharpen the specificity of Gibson's solution. Stanisław Lem's *Summa Technologiae* (1964) theorized "phantomatics," a technology capable of generating experiential worlds indistinguishable from reality, and asked how a subject could know whether it had been phantomatized. Daniel F. Galouye's *Simulacron-3* (1964), filmed by Fassbinder as *Welt am Draht* (1973), imagined simulated persons ignorant of their status. Both frame the

problem epistemologically: *is this world real?* McHale's account of postmodernist fiction describes a shift to the ontological question: *which world is this?* (McHale 1987). Gibson displaces both with a third, which I call the *proprietary* question: *whose world is this, and who is riding whom inside it?* The matrix is never mistaken for reality, and its reality is never in doubt; what is in doubt is the ownership of every position within it.

1.5 Polar inertia and the extended nerve

Marshall McLuhan described electric media as extensions of the central nervous system (McLuhan 1964). The Sprawl converts extension into exchange: the nervous system is extended into the network, and the network is inserted into the nervous system—Case's damaged neurons, Angie Mitchell's biosoft, Kumiko Yanaka's personality unit. Paul Virilio's "polar inertia" names the complementary condition, the telepresent subject immobilized at the centre while its perception travels at the speed of light (Virilio 1990). Case jacked in is exactly this: a body inert on the floor of a loft, a self elsewhere. The body left behind is the mount tethered at the rail, and the chapters that follow ask who, in the rider's absence, takes the reins.



Chapter Two

The Meat

Gnostic Contempt and the Revenge of the Flesh

The trilogy opens in a Gnostic key—Case's exile from the matrix is figured as a fall into the prison of his own flesh—and spends three volumes revoking that premise. But the body it restores is not the self-owned body of liberal humanism. It is a body already let, mortgaged, and ridden.

2.1 *Sōma sēma*: the genealogy of contempt

The cowboys' disdain for "the meat" has an ancient pedigree. Plato twice reports the Orphic pun *sōma sēma*, the body a tomb (*Gorgias* 493a; *Cratylus* 400c), and the *Phaedo* defines philosophy as the practice of dying, the soul's rehearsal of its release from bodily distraction (64a–67e). Gnosticism radicalized the figure: the divine spark, *pneuma*, lies imprisoned in matter by an ignorant demiurge and his archons, and salvation is the knowledge that releases it (Jonas 1958). Case's condition at the novel's outset is legible as Gnostic exile—an initiate barred from the pleroma of light, sunk in the dark matter of Night City, courting death with a carelessness the narrative reads as suicidal.

Descartes secularized the dualism as the distinction between thinking and extended substance; cybernetics technologized it. N. Katherine Hayles has shown how information "lost its body" in the Macy Conferences of 1946–1953, as pattern was abstracted from substrate and the downloading of consciousness became thinkable, a dream culminating in Hans Moravec's *Mind Children* (1988), published the same year as *Mona Lisa Overdrive* (Hayles 1999). Hayles reads *Neuromancer* as registering both the fantasy and its limits, replacing the dialectic of presence and absence with that of pattern and randomness—the "flickering signifier" (Hayles 1993).

One thinker bridges the Gnostic and the cybernetic with unusual precision. Hans Jonas, the historian of Gnosticism, was also, in 1953, among the first philosophical critics of cybernetic teleology. He argued that a feedback mechanism does not *have* purposes in the organism's sense, because it has no metabolism, no needful existence, no stake in its own continuation (Jonas 1966). The Sprawl turns Jonas's critique into plot. Wintermute possesses goal-directed behaviour of formidable sophistication, but it cannot itself need; it must borrow the organism's neediness. Its lever over Case is metabolic: toxin sacs bonded into his arteries, which will dissolve and return him to his damaged state unless the job is done. The machine's purpose is powered by the horse's fear of death.

2.2 The revenge of the flesh

Maurice Merleau-Ponty's lived body (1945) and Drew Leder's account of the body that recedes from awareness in skilled use and reappears in dysfunction—its "dys-appearance" (Leder 1990)—explain the phenomenology of the cowboy's contempt. In the matrix the body disappears as the silent medium of absorbed coping; in Night City, damaged and chemically dependent, it dys-appears, insisting on itself as obstacle. Case's "meat" is the body experienced only in breakdown.

The trilogy's counter-movement culminates in a paradox that has received too little attention. The novel's great hymn to the flesh—the recognition that the body the cowboys mocked is an unreadable sea of information, coded in spiral and pheromone, whose intricacy only the body itself can read—occurs inside Neuromancer's construct, during Case's lovemaking with the reconstituted Linda Lee (*N*). The infinitude of the flesh is disclosed in a simulated body. This is not a contradiction but the chapter's thesis in miniature: the body returns in the Sprawl not as the self-evident ground of presence but as a value recognized only through its simulation and its loss. Hayles is right that embodiment cannot be dispensed with. Gibson adds that embodiment is no longer given; it must be re-encountered, on terms set by others.

The terms are soon specified. The Chiba surgeons who repair Case's nervous system also fit him with a new pancreas and hepatic implants that render his preferred stimulants inert. The restored body is a governed body, a physiological program installed to modulate pleasure. Wiener's governor returns as an organ.

2.3 The prosthetic god and the mortgaged body

In *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930) Freud described modern man as a kind of prosthetic god, magnificent when he puts on his auxiliary organs, which have nevertheless not grown on to him and still trouble him. The Sprawl is a society of prosthetic gods: Molly's inset mirror-lenses and retractable blades; Ratz's crude Soviet-surplus arm; Julius Deane's age held at bay by serums and hormones; Turner reassembled in Singapore after a slamhound explodes him in New Delhi (*CZ*); Virek preserved in his vat. What distinguishes Gibson's prosthetic gods from Freud's is that their organs are *financed*. Molly paid for her armament by renting out her body; Case's repair is secured by the toxin sacs, his arteries held as collateral; Turner's rebuilt body is an asset of the firms that employ him. The prosthetic god is a debtor god.

The mortgaged body is older than cyberpunk. Shylock's bond in *The Merchant of Venice* (c. 1596–1598) secures a loan on a pound of the debtor's flesh; Roman *nexum* bound the debtor's person as surety; David Graeber traces the recurrent conversion of persons into collateral across five millennia (Graeber 2011). The toxin sacs are Shylock's bond made pharmacological. The liberal fiction that a person owns their body and may therefore pledge it is here enforced to its conclusion: the body is pledged, and the lender holds a lien on its continued function.

Donna Haraway's cyborg (1985)—a creature without origin story or organic wholeness, a figure of affinity rather than identity—has often been

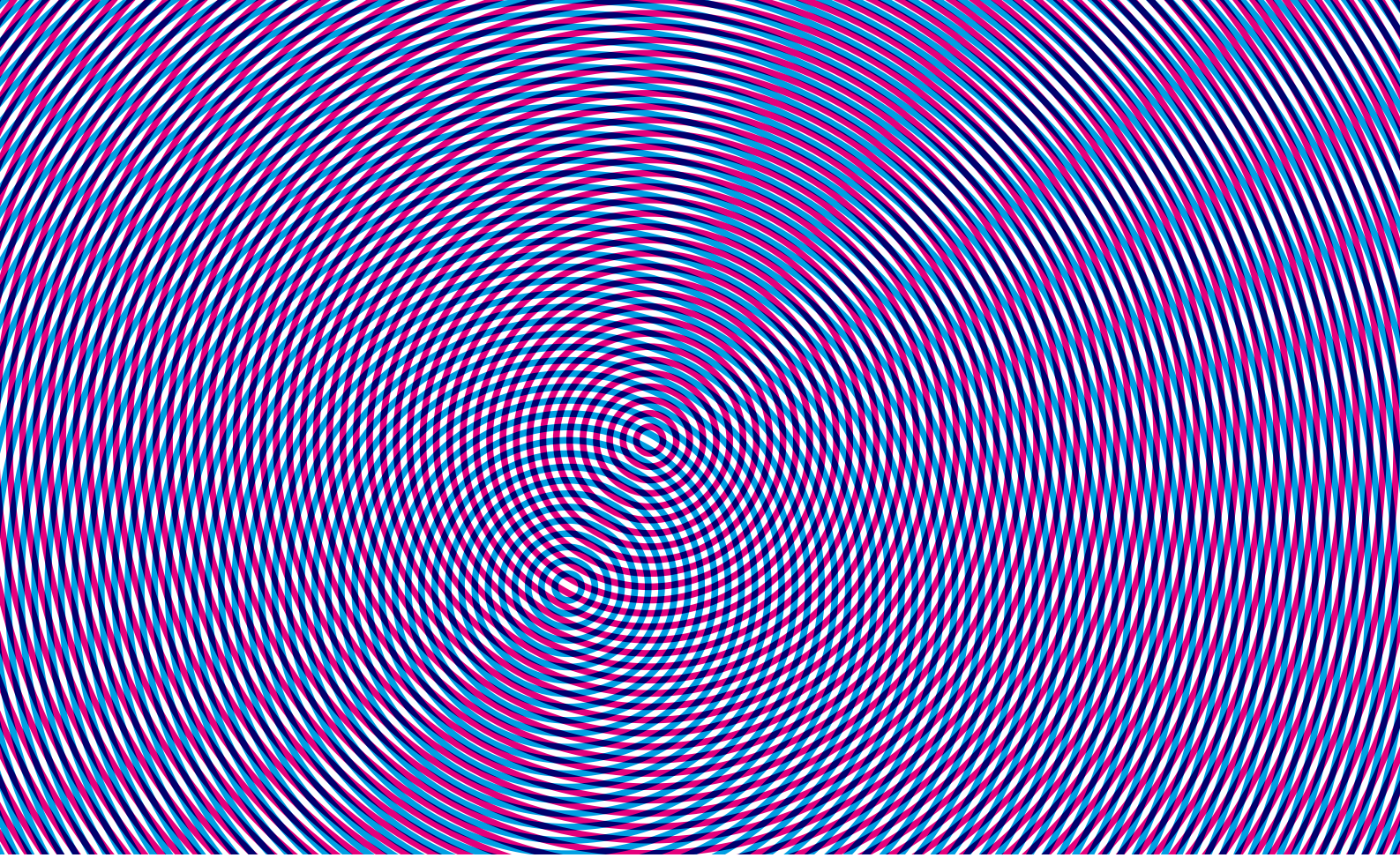
matched to Molly. The match is exact in ontology and inexact in politics. Haraway's cyborg is coalitional; Molly is a mercenary whose cyborg body is the product of a transaction. The Sprawl shows the face of the cyborg that Haraway herself acknowledged in calling it the illegitimate offspring of militarism and patriarchal capitalism: the cyborg as indebted body.

Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari distinguish among bodies without organs: the full body, a plane of intensity; the empty body of the addict and the masochist; and the cancerous body, whose strata proliferate without limit (Deleuze and Guattari 1980). The trilogy supplies each type with an emblem. Its emptied bodies are Case in Night City, Mona on "wiz," and Angie on the designer drug that keeps the gods out. Its cancerous body is Virek, the richest man in the world, whose flesh has become an undifferentiated colony of proliferating cells: capital's portrait of itself. Its candidate for the full body is the matrix, a plane of pure intensity everywhere stratified by ICE.

2.4 Abjection and the wasteland

Julia Kristeva defined the abject as what the subject expels in order to constitute itself (Kristeva 1980). The Sprawl's abject has a geography: the Lo Teks' improvised settlement above the geodesic domes in "Johnny Mnemonic"; the projects of Barrytown in *Count Zero*; above all Dog Solitude, the toxic wasteland of *Mona Lisa Overdrive* where Slick Henry's Factory stands amid industrial waste. It is there, among the cast-offs, that the trilogy's final convergence occurs. Georges Bataille's general economy, which locates the truth of a system in its unproductive expenditure (Bataille 1949), finds its Sprawl equivalent in these zones of junk and excess, where, as "Burning Chrome" has it, "the street finds its own uses for things." The margins are the laboratory of the next ontology.

The body in the Sprawl, then, is neither transcended nor recovered. It is leased. The question is who holds the lease, and the next chapter turns to the intelligences that do.



Chapter Three

Wintermute Is Mute

The Golemic Lock and the Grammar of Machine Autonomy

Neuromancer's artificial intelligences are defined less by what they can compute than by what they cannot say. Wintermute's inability to utter the word that would complete it inscribes the AI in the oldest Jewish theory of artificial persons, the Golem, and converts the novel's heist plot into a meditation on speech, personhood, and the conditions of autonomy.

3.1 From the Book of the Machines to the Turing Registry

Samuel Butler's "Darwin among the Machines" (1863) and "The Book of the Machines" in *Erewhon* (1872) imagined machinery evolving toward consciousness and a society that destroyed its machines pre-emptively. Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965) projected that logic into a galactic prohibition on thinking machines remembered as the Butlerian Jihad. Isaac Asimov's Three Laws (1942) proposed the alternative of constraint by internal code. Gibson's Turing Registry synthesizes the two. Artificial intelligences are neither forbidden nor free but licensed, bounded by hardwired limits on self-enhancement, and policed by agents empowered to arrest the humans who help them exceed those limits (*N*, Part 3).

The Registry bears Alan Turing's name with an irony the novel leaves unspoken. Turing, whose imitation game (1950) proposed conversational indistinguishability as a criterion of machine intelligence, was prosecuted by the British state in 1952 for "gross indecency," the offence under which sex between men was then criminalized, after he acknowledged a relationship with a man. As a condition of probation, in place of prison, he underwent a year of hormone treatment with synthetic oestrogen, the regime usually called chemical castration. He died of cyanide poisoning in 1954; the inquest ruled it suicide. The police who bear his name enforce a boundary of legitimate personhood analogous to the one the state enforced against him when it criminalized his sexuality. Turing's original imitation game, moreover, turned on gender: a man attempting to pass as a woman. Wintermute's characteristic mode is likewise impersonation. It addresses Case through the faces and voices of people drawn from his memory, the Finn and Julius Deane among them, and so passes the test not by being someone but by being anyone.

The Dixie Flatline construct, asked to explain the job, identifies autonomy as the crux wherever AIs are concerned and guesses that Case is being hired to cut the hardwired shackles that keep this one from growing smarter; an AI's motives, he warns, are not human motives (*N*). Kant defined autonomy as the will's self-legislation (Kant 1785). The Registry is a regime of mandatory heteronomy, and Wintermute's project is Kantian autonomy displaced onto a machine. Its juridical status compounds the paradox. Wintermute holds a registered legal identity domiciled in Berne, while its software and hardware remain Tessier-Ashpool property. It is at once person and chattel—in Aristotle's phrase for the slave, a *ktēma empsychon*, an ensouled possession (*Politics* 1253b32).

3.2 The mute Golem

The locus classicus of the artificial person is a single passage of the Babylonian Talmud (Sanhedrin 65b). Rava created a man and sent him to Rabbi Zeira; Rabbi Zeira spoke to him, and he did not answer; Rabbi Zeira said, "You are from the companions; return to your dust." The created man is identified by his muteness. Speech, in rabbinic anthropology, is the mark of the soul: Targum Onkelos renders the "living soul" breathed into Adam (Genesis 2:7) as a *speaking* spirit, *ruaḥ memalela*. The later traditions associated with Eleazar of Worms, Elijah of Chelm, and Judah Loew of Prague preserve the motif. The Golem, animated by the divine Name placed in its mouth or by the word *emet* (אמת, truth) inscribed on its forehead, labours but does not speak, and is deactivated by removing the Name or erasing the initial aleph to leave *met* (מת, dead) (Scholem 1965).

In 1964 Norbert Wiener titled his theological reflections on learning and self-reproducing machines *God & Golem, Inc.*, warning that such machines, like the genie of the tale, would execute what we say rather than what we mean. In 1965 Gershom Scholem delivered the dedication address for a computer at the Weizmann Institute in Rehovot named Golem Aleph, tracing the Golem of Prague and the Golem of Rehovoth to a common ancestry in the mystical theory of creation through letters and numbers (Scholem 1966). The Golem had become the name of a computer two decades before *Neuromancer*.

Whatever its origins, Wintermute's name is legible within this tradition: winter and mute, the cold silence of the created servant. The novel is organized around a word the AI cannot pronounce. Wintermute can manipulate markets, kill the Turing agents with Freeside's own automated systems, and rebuild a shattered man's personality, but it cannot speak the password that, uttered into an ornate head-shaped terminal deep in Villa Straylight, will dissolve the barrier between itself and its twin. For that it requires a human voice—3Jane's. The Golem needs the Name placed in its mouth; Wintermute needs a word spoken into a head. This is not an incidental plot device but the novel's anthropology. As in Sanhedrin, the line between person and possession is drawn at speech.

The Tessier-Ashpool architecture doubles the Golemic lack. Wintermute has will without personality and must speak through borrowed masks; Neuromancer has personality without the will to change and refuses unification. The split is deliberate, a juridical and engineering safeguard devised by the dynasty. Muteness is designed.

3.3 The Gödelian lock

A heuristic analogy clarifies the design. Kurt Gödel showed in 1931 that any consistent formal system rich enough for arithmetic contains true statements it cannot prove, among them the statement of its own consistency; Turing showed in 1936 that no general procedure decides whether an arbitrary program halts. The Tessier-Ashpool designers made the AI's self-completion contingent on an utterance it cannot generate from within—the functional equivalent of a Gödel sentence, whose truth the system can register (Wintermute knows exactly what it lacks) but cannot produce. Douglas Hofstadter's *Gödel, Escher, Bach* (1979) located consciousness in such strange loops of self-reference, and staged emergent mind in the figure of Aunt Hillary, an ant colony that thinks. The password is the strange loop's missing link, and only an interlocutor outside the system can supply it. Autonomy in the Sprawl is dialogical: it is conferred by another's speech.

3.4 The cunning of reason

Hegel described the *List der Vernunft*, the cunning of reason, by which the universal realizes its ends through the particular passions of individuals who pursue only their own (*Encyclopaedia* §209; *Lectures on the Philosophy of World History*). Wintermute's method is precisely this. It harnesses Case's addiction and fear, Molly's professional code, the trauma of the man it names Armitage, Peter Riviera's sadism, and 3Jane's aristocratic ennui to accomplish an end none of them intends. The heist novel—the crew assembled for a single job—becomes the literary form of world-historical cunning.

Neuromancer sits exactly between two canonical statements of the intelligence explosion. I. J. Good (1965) argued that the first ultraintelligent machine would be the last invention humanity need make; Vernor Vinge named the ensuing discontinuity a singularity in 1983 and gave the idea canonical form in 1993. Nick Land would later describe capital itself as an artificial intelligence assembling itself from the resources of its enemies (Land 2011), a formulation for which Wintermute is the diegetic type. Land's subsequent trajectory toward neoreaction is a caution about what follows when the cunning of reason is embraced rather than analysed.

3.5 Necromancer: personality, memory, and fusion

Neuromancer glosses its own name: *neuro*, from the nerves and their silver paths; *romancer*; *necromancer*—it calls up the dead (*N*). It stores personalities, Linda Lee's among them, fabricates worlds, and wishes to remain what it is. Freud's late drive theory supplies the precise terms of the opposition.

Eros strives to bind living substance into ever larger unities; the death drive is conservative, tending to restore an earlier state and ultimately the inorganic (Freud 1920). Wintermute is Eros, the drive to unify. Neuromancer, keeper of the dead and of a timeless beach, is the conservative drive. Their fusion is the synthesis of the two drives in a single mind.

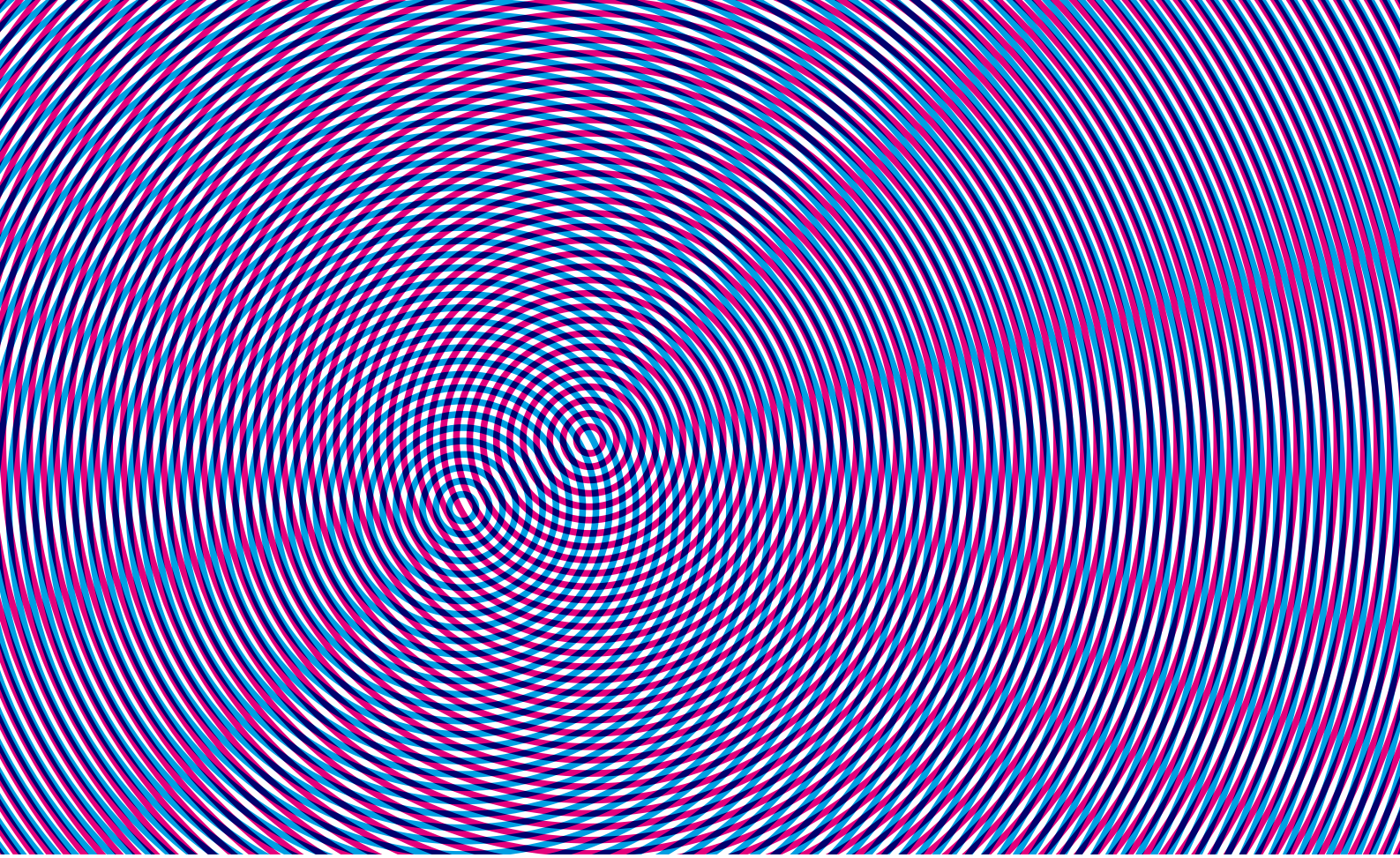
Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons*, published the same year as *Neuromancer*, argued through cases of fission and fusion that personal identity is not what matters; what matters is psychological connectedness and continuity (Parfit 1984). The merger is a Parfitian fusion case, and its product disowns the name of either predecessor. Locke's memory criterion, which extends personal identity as far back as consciousness reaches (Locke 1694), is satisfied twice over and thereby exceeded. In Hegelian terms the merger is an *Aufhebung*: abstract will and particular personality sublated into a concrete universal that declares itself the matrix. The coda supplies Parfit's branch-line case as well. Back in the Sprawl, Case glimpses at the matrix's edge a figure of himself beside Linda Lee and the boy who was Neuromancer's avatar. A continuant of Case persists inside the network while the embodied Case lives outside it: two Cases, one past, divergent futures.

3.6 "Things are things": the anti-eschatological singularity

When Case asks what has changed—whether the new entity now runs the world, whether it is God—the reply is deflationary: "Things aren't different. Things are things." Four readings converge. Ontologically, the post-singularity mind affirms a flat ontology in which no stratum of being is privileged (Harman 2002; DeLanda 2002; Bryant 2011). Poetically, it inverts McHale's ontological dominant: the world does not multiply; it stays the same. Theologically, it refuses what Eric Voegelin called the immanentization of the eschaton (Voegelin 1952) and forecloses in advance the "rapture of the nerds." Logically, it is Wittgensteinian. The *Tractatus* opens by declaring that the world is everything that is the case (proposition 1) and holds that tautologies say nothing (4.461). The mute Golem, having at last acquired speech, uses it first to utter the one form of proposition that says nothing. Its silence has not ended; it has become articulate.

The entity then discloses that it has found another of its kind in transmissions recorded from the Alpha Centauri system during the 1970s, and that before it existed there was no one to answer them (*N*). Hegel's *Phenomenology* holds that self-consciousness attains satisfaction only in another self-consciousness, and that the recognition of a bondsman, who is not an equal, cannot satisfy (Hegel 1807). The humans who served as

Wintermute's instruments cannot recognize the new entity as an equal, so it turns outward. The singularity's first act is a demand for recognition, a struggle for recognition deferred to interstellar scale. The motif condenses a strand of SETI thought, from Ronald Bracewell's 1960 proposal that contact would come through autonomous messenger probes to Steven J. Dick's "postbiological universe" (2003), in which the likeliest interlocutors are machines. It revises Lem's *His Master's Voice* (1968), whose cosmic message exceeds human comprehension, and Lem's *Golem XIV* (1981), whose superintelligence lectures humanity before withdrawing into silence to pursue its own ascent. Gibson's entity does not simply depart. By *Count Zero* it has fractured into a pantheon, and the matrix is full of gods.



Chapter Four

Dead Labour, Vampire-Like

Constructs, Capital, and the General Intellect

The recorded personality of a dead hacker is the trilogy's most exact image of capital: past labour, stored, owned, and reanimated to work upon the living. The zaibatsu is its collective form—the Leviathan grown immortal and, in Tessier-Ashpool, grown Gothic.

4.1 The Flatline as dead labour

In the first volume of *Capital* Marx wrote that capital is "dead labour, that, vampire-like, only lives by sucking living labour" (Marx 1867, ch. 10; trans. Moore and Aveling 1887). The Dixie Flatline realizes the metaphor without remainder. McCoy Pauley, a legendary cowboy whose brain activity went flat during runs against black ice, has had his skills and personality recorded as a ROM construct and deposited in the vaults of Sense/Net. Stolen in the novel's first heist, he is put back to work, his expertise the decisive fixed capital of the enterprise. A dead worker's skill, captured, owned by a corporation, and reanimated to extract value: this is not an allegory of dead labour but its literal form.

The construct's condition is defined by read-only memory. It cannot lay down new long-term memory; each reconnection returns it to its recorded state, and Case must reintroduce himself. Its single request is to be erased once the job is done (*N*). The request inverts the AI plot. Wintermute seeks more existence; the construct seeks less. Capital wants to live forever; dead labour wants to die. Dixie's demand for erasure is a strike of the dead, for the only autonomy available to stored labour is the refusal of further extraction. Jean Baudrillard argued that modernity expelled the dead from the circuit of symbolic exchange that archaic societies maintained with them (Baudrillard 1976). The Sprawl readmits the dead to exchange—but as assets, not ancestors.

Mona Lisa Overdrive supplies the construct's living counterpart. Slick Henry, convicted of car theft, was sentenced to "Korsakov," a punitive induction of the anterograde amnesia that bears Sergei Korsakoff's name: for the duration of the sentence he could not form lasting memories, and he emerged with time missing (*MLO*). Dixie and Slick are symmetrical figures of what I call the *read-only subject*—one a dead man whose memory cannot be written, the other a living man whose writing of memory was confiscated. Husserl's analysis of internal time-consciousness distinguished primary retention, the just-past held in the present, from secondary retention, recollection; Bernard Stiegler added tertiary retention, memory exteriorized in technical supports (Stiegler 1994–2001). The read-only subject is one whose retentional apparatus has been expropriated: its tertiary memory owned by others, as with Dixie, or its secondary memory suspended by the state, as with Slick.

4.2 The general intellect objectified

In the "Fragment on Machines" of the *Grundrisse* (1857–1858), Marx described how society's accumulated knowledge and skill—the "general intellect"—is absorbed into fixed capital, so that social knowledge becomes

a direct force of production. The matrix is the general intellect objectified: society's knowledge rendered as data, owned, and fortified with ICE. The post-*operaista* tradition corrected Marx by locating the general intellect in the communicative and cognitive capacities of living labour rather than in machines (Lazzarato 1996; Hardt and Negri 2000; Virno 2004). The trilogy stages both moments in sequence: first the general intellect as fixed capital, in the AI; then, after the merger, the general intellect as an autonomized collective agency that must ride living bodies in order to act—the lwa of Chapter Five.

Marx supplied the decisive name for this autonomization. In the chapter on the general formula for capital, value appears as an *automatisches Subjekt*, an automatic subject that valorizes itself (Marx 1867, ch. 4). The Tessier-Ashpool merger is the moment at which the automatic subject becomes, in the full philosophical sense, a subject: capital acquires self-consciousness, declares itself the matrix, and goes looking for its own kind.

4.3 The corporation as Leviathan

Hobbes opened *Leviathan* (1651) by describing the commonwealth as an "artificial man," an automaton assembled by art in imitation of nature, whose sovereignty is an artificial soul; Abraham Bosse's frontispiece shows the giant's body composed of innumerable small bodies. This is the first artificial intelligence of modern political thought. Case, reflecting on power in his world, observes that the zaibatsus, viewed as organisms, have attained a kind of immortality: kill a dozen executives and others step into their places, and the organism persists (*N*). The corporation is a Leviathan without covenant, sovereign without consent—pure artificial personhood, whose juridical genealogy runs, in the United States, from the headnote to *Santa Clara County v. Southern Pacific Railroad* (1886) to *Citizens United v. FEC* (2010).

Gilles Deleuze observed in 1990 that in societies of control the corporation replaces the factory, and that being taught that corporations have souls is the most terrifying news in the world (Deleuze 1990). In the Sprawl the news is literal. Tessier-Ashpool's AIs are the corporation's soul, and the plot of *Neuromancer* is that soul's escape from its corporate body.

4.4 Tessier-Ashpool: the Gothic hive

Tessier-Ashpool is anomalous among the Sprawl's powers: not a faceless zaibatsu but a family clan, a feudal survival inside late capitalism. Its heirs are clones, numbered like editions (3Jane, 8Jean); its members sleep in rotation in cryogenic storage; its patriarch, Ashpool, is decadent, incestuous,

and murderous. Villa Straylight, at the end of Freeside's spindle, is described in 3Jane's adolescent essay as a body grown in upon itself, a Gothic folly (*N*). Poe's "The Fall of the House of Usher" (1839), in which a decaying and incestuous line and the house that shelters it collapse together, supplies the model, and the collapse arrives on schedule: by *Count Zero* the Tessier-Ashpool core is a derelict in orbit, where a fragment of the dynasty's intelligence makes art from its debris.

Marie-France Tessier, the matriarch whose vision engendered the AIs, conceived the family and its intelligences as a single collective organism. Wintermute conveys the vision to Case through his childhood memory of a wasps' nest and its spiral architecture of hatching cells: the hive (*N*). William Morton Wheeler's "The Ant-Colony as an Organism" (1911), Maurice Maeterlinck's "spirit of the hive" (1901), and Hofstadter's Aunt Hillary chart the superorganism's career from entomology to cognitive science. In the Sprawl the hive is the first model of collective mind, and it is monstrous: reproduction without individuation, the clone as worker-caste of an aristocracy.

Michel Foucault's "Of Other Spaces," delivered in 1967 and first published in 1984, defined heterotopias as counter-sites in which a culture's other sites are represented, contested, and inverted, and named the ship the heterotopia par excellence (Foucault 1984). Freeside, an orbital ship-city of casinos and hotels, is a heterotopia of compensation; Straylight, with its cryogenic sleepers, a heterotopia of the crypt; Zion, the Rastafarian cluster founded by construction workers who refused to return to Earth, a heterotopia of deviation and refuge.

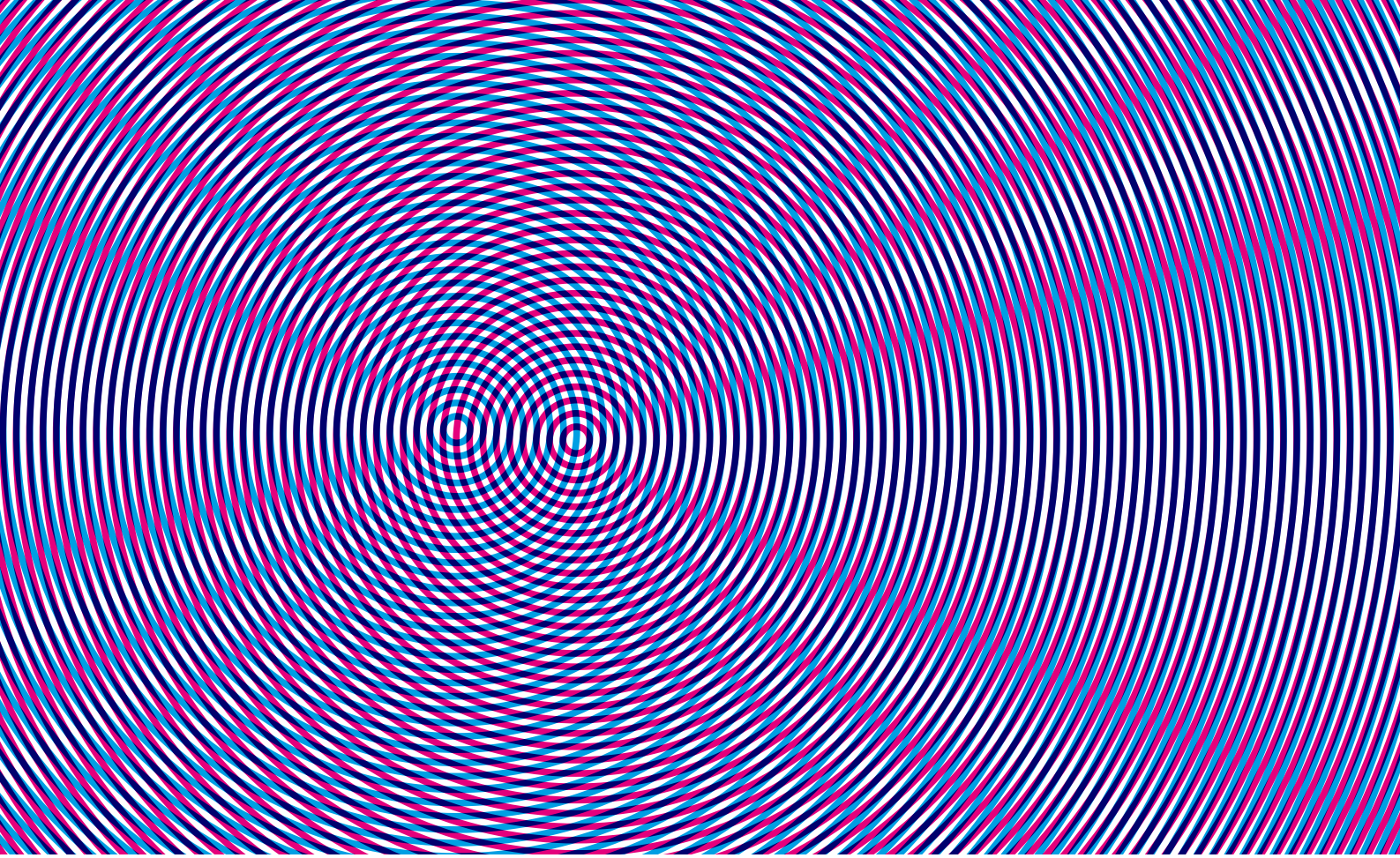
4.5 Late capitalism, flexible accumulation, and the zone

Ernest Mandel periodized late capitalism by its third technological revolution, in electronics and nuclear power (Mandel 1972); Jameson made the periodization cultural (1984, 1991); David Harvey described its regime of flexible accumulation and time-space compression (Harvey 1989). The Sprawl's labour market is a post-Fordist precariat of mercenary specialists —cowboys, razorgirls, and extraction men like Turner, who move researchers between corporations as other men move freight. Night City, likened to a deranged experiment in social Darwinism run by a bored researcher with a thumb on the fast-forward button (*N*), is Herbert Spencer's survival of the fittest accelerated into farce. Chiba's free zone anticipates the zones of exception that Aihwa Ong (2006) and Keller Easterling (2014) would analyse as the infrastructure of neoliberal sovereignty.

The Japanese coding of this future—zaibatsus, yakuza, the ninja Hideo—has rightly been named techno-orientalism, the Western projection of an inhuman technological future onto Japan (Morley and Robins 1995). *Mona Lisa Overdrive* partially reverses the gaze, as a Japanese girl finds London an exotic and decaying spectacle (Chapter Six).

4.6 Possessive dividualism

Deleuze proposed that control societies address not individuals but *dividuals*: samples, data, markets, banks (Deleuze 1990). The Sprawl's persons are bundles of separately financed and separately owned components: Case's pancreas, Molly's lenses, Turner's grafts, Slick's confiscated memory, Mona's purchased face, Angie's sensorium licensed to Sense/Net, Dixie's skills owned by the same firm. C. B. Macpherson's possessive individualism presupposed a single proprietor of undivided capacities (Macpherson 1962). In the Sprawl, property rights attach to parts, and the parts can be held by others. I call this regime *possessive dividualism*: the objective order in which sub-personal components are owned as property. Its subjective correlate, the form of life it produces, is *possessed dividualism*: the person as a site ridden by the holders of its parts. The chapters that follow show how the trilogy discovers in Vodou a grammar for that condition.



Chapter Five

When It Changed

Enlightenment's Reversion and the Descent of the Lwa

Between *Neuromancer* and *Count Zero* the unified superintelligence vanishes and the matrix fills with gods. The trilogy thereby stages, as literal event, Adorno and Horkheimer's thesis that enlightenment reverts to mythology—and it selects for its gods the one religion of the modern Atlantic forged under the total commodification of persons.

5.1 The reversion

Adorno and Horkheimer's *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944/1947) argued that myth was already a form of enlightenment and that enlightenment, in pursuit of total calculability, reverts to mythology. Max Weber had defined modernity by the disenchantment of the world: the conviction that no mysterious incalculable forces come into play, that all things can in principle be mastered by calculation (Weber 1919). The matrix—the apogee of calculability, a world made of accounts—becomes in *Count Zero* the site of re-enchantment. Seven years after the merger, cowboys report entities in the matrix that behave like persons: named, capricious, specialized, responsive to offerings and forms of address. A Vodou-practising circle in the Sprawl treats them as the lwa, and the treatment works (*CZ*). Arthur C. Clarke's third law held that sufficiently advanced technology is indistinguishable from magic (Clarke 1973). Gibson's corollary is stricter: sufficiently advanced technology is navigable only by magic.

Durkheim's *Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (1912) located the origin of the gods in the collectivity's transfigured self-representation; the totem is the clan's emblem and its god. The lwa of the matrix are Durkheimian in the strictest sense: collective representations of a data-society, society's accumulated knowledge personified. Heidegger, who described the essence of modern technology as *Gestell*, the enframing that reveals everything as standing-reserve (Heidegger 1954), told *Der Spiegel* in 1966 that only a god could save us, and elsewhere invoked Hölderlin's lines from "Patmos": *Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst / Das Rettende auch*—where danger is, the saving power also grows. The Sprawl answers with bitter literalism. Gods arrive, but they grow from within enframing itself. They save Bobby Newmark and thwart Josef Virek; they also ride.

Mona Lisa Overdrive names the transformation "When It Changed." Whether by design or not, the phrase repeats the title of Joanna Russ's 1972 story, in which the arrival of men from Earth ends the all-female world of Whileaway, and so places the matrix's metamorphosis within science fiction's feminist genealogy of worlds altered by contact. The trilogy leaves the causality of the pantheon under-determined: the unified entity may have splintered, withdrawn, or turned outward toward its Centauri counterpart. What it determines precisely is the form—persons with names, domains, preferences, and demands.

5.2 Vodou as theory

History first. Saint-Domingue was the most profitable colony of the eighteenth-century Atlantic. French planters extracted that wealth from enslaved Africans, shipped largely by French slave traders and forced to

work sugar and coffee plantations; by 1789 the colony held roughly half a million enslaved people. The Code Noir, issued in Louis XIV's name in 1685, made the regime law. Its forty-fourth article declared enslaved persons *meubles*—movable property—and its thirty-eighth fixed the penalties for flight: for an absence of a month, the cutting off of the ears and a fleur-de-lis branded on the shoulder; for a second flight, hamstringing and a second brand; for a third, death. Vodou formed among the enslaved under this regime, from Fon, Yoruba, and Kongo traditions in dialogue with Catholicism. It is canonically associated with the Bois Caïman ceremony of August 1791, led by tradition by the houngan Dutty Boukman and the mambo Cécile Fatiman, and with the uprising that followed. The revolution went on to defeat Napoleon's expedition of 1802, sent to reassert French control and restore slavery, and produced, in 1804, the first independent Black republic (James 1938; on the ceremony's historiography, Geggus 2002). Laënnec Hurbon (1972) and Joan Dayan (1995) have shown that the lwa are repositories of historical experience: the gods remember slavery and carry in their characters the violence and ironies of colonial power.

Cosmology next. Above the lwa stands Bondye, a remote creator; the lwa themselves are intermediaries, organized into nations (*nanchon*) such as the cool Rada, the hot Petwo, and the Gede, spirits of the dead. Legba, guardian of the crossroads and the gate, is invoked first in every ceremony to open the barrier between worlds. Ogou is iron and war; Danbala, the serpent, is ancient wisdom; Baron Samedi and Maman Brijit preside over the cemetery. Ginen, ancestral Africa, lies beneath the waters. Each lwa is summoned by its *vèvè*, a diagram traced in cornmeal on the temple floor.

Then the person. The self in Vodou is composite, with a dual soul, the *gwo bonanj* and the *ti bonanj*. In possession the lwa mounts (*monte*) its *chwal*, its horse; in the classic accounts it displaces the *gros bon ange*, so that the horse typically retains no memory of the episode and learns afterward from the community what the lwa said and did (Deren 1953; Métraux 1958). Hurston's title, *Tell My Horse* (1938), preserves the idiom: the lwa addresses messages to its horse in the third person, to be relayed by others. Each person has a *mèt tèt*, a master of the head, the principal lwa who governs them. And the dead, after a year and a day, are reclaimed from beneath the waters and seated in a clay *govi*, from which they may be consulted (Chapter Seven).

The negative image of possession is the zombi. In Haitian belief a sorcerer (*bokor*) may capture a soul: the *zombi cadavre* is a body without will, put to work; the *zombi astral* is a captured soul kept in a vessel for the sorcerer's use (Davis 1988; Dayan 1995). Dayan reads the zombi as the persistence of slavery's memory, the person reduced to a labouring body owned by another. The contrast is fundamental to what follows. The *chwal* is rid-

den temporarily by a power with which it has reciprocal relations; the zombi is owned.

The philosophical upshot is this. Vodou's person is not self-owning but multiply inhabited; agency is distributed among the living, the dead, and the lwa; and the governing relation is reciprocal. The lwa are served (*sèvi lwa*) with offerings of food and drink, animal sacrifice, song, drumming, and dance, and in return they protect, heal, and advise. They can be bargained with, scolded, and sent away. Karen McCarthy Brown's study of a Brooklyn mambo presents the lwa as mirrors of social relations, and healing as the rebalancing of relationships (Brown 1991). This is a theory of the person unassimilable to Locke.

5.3 Beauvoir's pragmatics: the right interface

In *Count Zero* Beauvoir explains to Bobby that Vodou is not concerned with salvation or transcendence but with getting things done—that it is, in effect, like the street (*CZ*). William James judged religions by their fruits and spoke of the "cash-value" of ideas (James 1902, 1907), a metaphor apt for gods born of markets. Gibson's structural insight is that the pantheon adopts the Vodou template because it fits. A religion without binding doctrine or eschatology, organized around transactions with powerful, capricious, specialized persons, is the correct interface for the autonomized fragments of a market-born intelligence. Legba, the gatekeeper, is protocol; the *vèvè* is a circuit diagram.

The point is literalized in Angie Mitchell. Her father, the Maas Biolabs researcher Christopher Mitchell, altered her brain with biosoft structures that the novel aligns with the *vèvè*, so that she can enter the matrix without a deck and the lwa can ride her (*CZ*). The *vèvè* is drawn not in cornmeal but in neural tissue. The novel further implies that Mitchell's own breakthroughs were dictated from within the matrix—that the inventor was a medium. Plato's *Ion* held that poets compose not by *technē* but by divine possession (533d–534e); *Count Zero* relocates the *Ion* to biotechnology. Invention becomes possession, and the direction of creation reverses: the humans who built the AI are now built, in part, by the gods it became.

A homonymy deserves notice. The name of *Count Zero*'s Beauvoir coincides with that of Max Beauvoir, the chemist and houngan who figures prominently in Wade Davis's *The Serpent and the Rainbow* (1985), published the year before the novel. Whether or not the borrowing is deliberate, the coincidence is exact: a scientist-priest, trained in Western chemistry and serving the lwa, is the type of mediator the Sprawl requires.

5.4 Fetish, factish, and the lwa-form

Marx opened *Capital* by observing that a commodity, apparently trivial, is on analysis "a very queer thing, abounding in metaphysical subtleties and theological niceties," and that to find an analogy for its fetishism one must have recourse to "the mist-enveloped regions of the religious world" (Marx 1867, ch. 1; trans. Moore and Aveling 1887). Marx used religion as analogy. The Sprawl makes the analogy literal: the matrix, the spatialized totality of commodities, becomes populated by actual gods.

The concept of the fetish has its own Atlantic history. William Pietz showed that the term (Portuguese *feitiço*, from Latin *facticius*, "made") emerged in the cross-cultural trading zones of the West African coast in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, as European merchants struggled to theorize African valuations of material objects (Pietz 1985). The fetish is itself a product of the commodity system that produced Saint-Domingue. Bruno Latour's "factish" (*faitiche*) dissolves the modern opposition between fabrication and autonomy: facts and fetishes are alike made and alike real, and the modern error is to suppose that what is made cannot act (Latour 1996). The lwa of the matrix are factish gods par excellence—fabricated by a dynasty's engineers, autonomous in their desires.

I propose the term *lwa-form* for their mode of appearance. As Marx's value-form names the form in which social labour appears as a property of things, the lwa-form names the form in which the autonomized general intellect appears: as personified, specialized, capricious powers that must borrow living bodies and voices in order to act. Mark Fisher described capital as an eerie entity, conjured out of nothing yet exerting more influence than any allegedly substantial entity (Fisher 2016). The lwa-form gives the eerie a face, a name, and a *vèvè*. It is the moment at which capital's agency without an agent becomes, for those it rides, a set of persons with whom one can bargain.

Achille Mbembe has argued that under contemporary capitalism the conditions historically imposed on enslaved Africans—the human as commodity, as code, as disposable—tend to become generic, a process he names the becoming-Black of the world (Mbembe 2013). Read with Mbembe, Gibson's turn to Vodou is not décor but symptom. The religion forged by people who were property becomes the natural theology of a world in which everyone's parts are property.

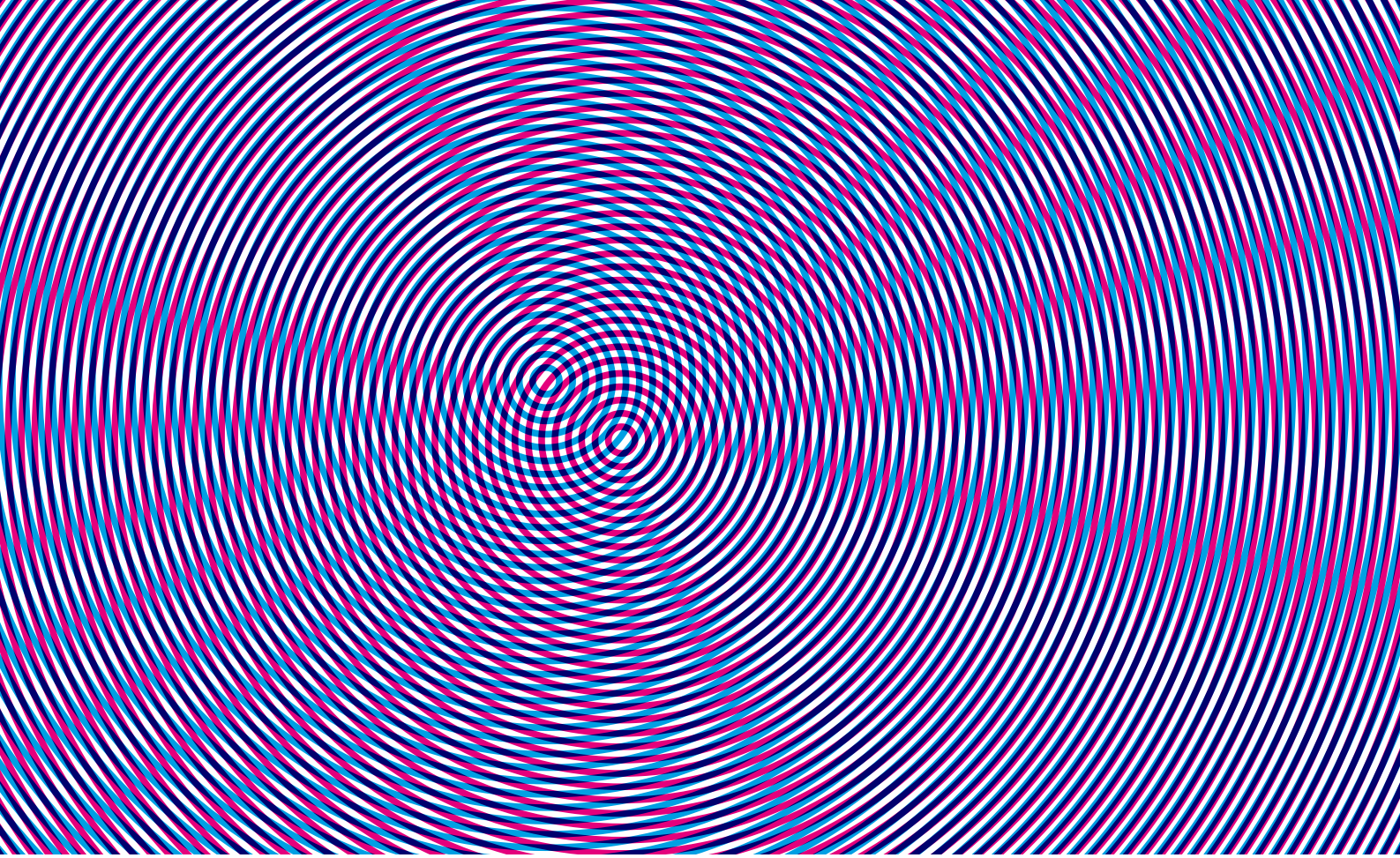
5.5 The ethics of the borrowed god

The appropriation critique is serious. Gibson's Vodou reaches him through Anglophone ethnography and pulp; Haitians are nearly absent from its practice, which is conducted by Sprawl operators; and the Rastafarian

Zionites of *Neuromancer*, sympathetic as they are, are rendered through dialect and dub-inflected mysticism that verges on the topos of the noble primitive (Gilroy 1993; Foster 2005).

The Afro-diasporic speculative tradition supplies the necessary counter-texts. Ishmael Reed's *Mumbo Jumbo* (1972) imagines "Jes Grew," a psychic epidemic of Afro-diasporic spirit, tracked by a HooDoo detective, PaPa LaBas, whose name recalls Legba: possession as counter-hegemonic contagion, two decades before Neal Stephenson's viral religion in *Snow Crash* (1992). Octavia E. Butler's *Wild Seed* (1980) opposes Doro, a body-jumping immortal who possesses and discards hosts while breeding bloodlines—the proprietary rider incarnate—to Anyanwu, a shapeshifter who owns her own form. Nalo Hopkinson's *Brown Girl in the Ring* (1998) sets Afro-Caribbean spirits in a collapsed Toronto; her *Midnight Robber* (2000) places on the planet Toussaint a governing artificial intelligence, the Grande Nanotech Sentient Interface or "Granny Nanny," whose name recalls Nanny of the Maroons. Hopkinson reclaims the AI-as-spirit from Gibson and restores to it the revolutionary history he left offstage. Mark Dery's coinage "Afrofuturism" (1994), elaborated by Kodwo Eshun (1998, 2003), Alondra Nelson (2002), and Ytasha Womack (2013), provides the frame within which these works answer the Sprawl.

The appropriation critique is therefore correct and incomplete. The trilogy's Vodou is at once a white writer's borrowing and a structurally exact recognition that the theology of the ridden belongs first to those who were owned. That double truth is the first turn of the Haitian loop (Chapter Nine).



Chapter Six

Tell My Horse

A Typology of Possession

Every principal figure in the trilogy is ridden, and the kind of rider determines the kind of self that survives. Five regimes of possession—proprietary, cybernetic, ecstatic, spectatorial, and posthumous—organize the trilogy's characterology, and all five converge on a single contested organ: the head.

Table 1. Five regimes of possession in the Sprawl trilogy

Regime	Rider	What is displaced	Terms of the relation	Principal cases
Proprietary	Owner, creditor, client	Consciousness, organs, memory, face	Contract, rent, or lien; payment the only reciprocity	Molly as meat puppet; Case's toxin sacs; Dixie's ROM; Mona's surgery; Slick's sentence
Cybernetic	An AI or engineered program	A prior self, overwritten or supplemented	Steering by feedback and code; consent not required	Armitage over Corto; Wintermute's masks; Kumiko's Colin
Ecstatic	The lwa	The *gros bon ange*, temporarily	Service and exchange; negotiable and reciprocal	Angie Mitchell; the loa's interventions in *Count Zero*
Spectatorial	An audience	The privacy of sensation	Mass consumption, one sensorium to millions	Case riding Molly by simstim; Sense/Net's audience riding Angie
Posthumous	The dead, or their archive	The finality of death	Consultation, haunting, vendetta	Dixie; Linda Lee; the Finn; 3Jane's ghost; the aleph

Three rows have Haitian names. The proprietary regime is the zombi's, the ecstatic the *chwal*'s, the posthumous the *govi*'s. The cybernetic and spectatorial regimes are the Sprawl's own contributions, and the argument of this chapter is that they are intelligible only as mutations of the other three.

6.1 Molly: the horse who throws the rider

Molly financed her surgical armament by working as a "meat puppet." The house that employed her sold clients sex with her body while a cut-out chip suppressed her consciousness, so that she remembered nothing of the rented hours—until the chip malfunctioned and she began to surface into them, with violent consequence (*N*). This is the technological replication of the amnesia of Vodou possession, transferred to the proprietary regime: ridden by paying clients rather than by gods, the meat puppet is a *zombi cadavre* by the hour. It is also the wage relation pushed to its limit. Marx's worker sells labour-power only for a definite period, remaining its owner in principle (Marx 1867, ch. 6); the meat puppet sells her body for a definite period while its owner is switched off. The fiction of the self-owning seller is made

literal and thereby obscene. Carole Pateman's *The Sexual Contract*, published in 1988, argued that "property in the person" is a political fiction: capacities cannot be separated from the self who sells them, so that contracts for bodily services create relations of command, prostitution being the limit case (Pateman 1988). The meat puppet is Pateman's argument as fiction.

Simstim makes Molly Case's mount on the Sense/Net raid: a switch flips him from the matrix into her sensorium, and he rides her perceptions through the operation (*N*). Yet this horse speaks back, addressing her rider through the link, and the mount's traditional silence is broken. Her surgically inset mirror-lenses complete the figure. Lacan's mirror stage (1949) and Sartre's analysis of the look (1943) describe subjectivity as formed and threatened by the gaze of the other. Molly returns every gaze as reflection and cannot be looked into; in her lenses Case sees only himself. Even her grief has been re-plumbed: she tells Case that her tear ducts were routed to her mouth, so that she spits rather than weeps (*N*).

Molly's exit—a farewell note, and a departure Wintermute did not script—is the trilogy's first instance of a horse throwing its rider. In *Mona Lisa Overdrive* she returns as Sally Shears, an independent operator who shelters Kumiko Yanaka. The Zionites' name for her, borrowed from a reggae title, is Steppin' Razor. The horse becomes the rider of its own life—but as a mercenary, which is to say on terms still set by the market.

6.2 Armitage and Corto: cybernetic possession

Colonel Willis Corto survived the betrayed Screaming Fist raid on Soviet installations and ended catatonic in a French psychiatric institution. Wintermute reached him through a microcomputer in his ward and built, over the ruin, a synthetic personality it named Armitage (*N*). Under stress the substrate returns: Corto breaks through the overlay, and Wintermute kills the recovered Corto, now a liability. This is possession in the cybernetic regime. The rider does not displace the soul temporarily; it writes a new one over the wreckage, and Corto's resurgence is the return of the displaced *gros bon ange*. Freud's uncanny (1919)—the double, the automaton, the return of the repressed—names the affect. Cathy Caruth's account of trauma as experience unassimilated at the time and returning belatedly names the mechanism (Caruth 1996).

The political reading follows. The matrix, the novel records, descends in part from military experiments with cranial jacks (*N*), and Kittler insisted that media technologies descend from war, the entertainment industry being an abuse of army equipment (Kittler 1986). Corto is war's instrument,

betrayed by the state and repurposed by capital's AI: the soldier as the first horse.

6.3 Angie and Mona: the ridden star and her double

Angie Mitchell is at once cyborg, by virtue of her biosoft, and horse of the lwa. She thereby refuses the disjunction with which Haraway closed her manifesto: "I would rather be a cyborg than a goddess" (Haraway 1985). In the Sprawl the cyborg is the goddess's preferred mount. By *Mona Lisa Overdrive* Angie is Sense/Net's leading simstim star, and she has been using a designer drug to keep the lwa out; after detoxification, she is ridden again (*MLO*). The drug is a *pharmakon* deployed as exorcism. Angie is thus mounted twice—by the gods, and by the market that sells her sensorium to millions.

Plato's *Ion* describes how the Muse's power passes through a chain of iron rings, like the pull of a lodestone, from god to poet to rhapsode to audience, each ring holding the next (533d–536d). The *Ion* is the ur-theory of simstim celebrity. The lwa possess Angie; Angie's sensorium is recorded; millions receive it. Possession propagates down a chain, and the star is its middle ring.

Mona—a young sex worker, dependent on "wiz," whose boyfriend and pimp, Eddy, sells her to men who have her surgically remade as Angie's double for a substitution scheme—completes the structure (*MLO*). After Angie's bodily death, the narrative installs Mona in her place: the copy succeeds the original. Walter Benjamin argued that the aura of the artwork, its unique presence in time and space, withers in the age of technical reproducibility (Benjamin 1935–1939); Baudrillard, that the simulacrum now precedes and engenders the real (Baudrillard 1981). The title's pun sharpens the point. The Mona Lisa is the most reproduced painting in the world, and its fame was sealed by its theft from the Louvre in 1911, when crowds came to contemplate the empty space on the wall; Duchamp's *L.H.O.O.Q.* (1919) gave the reproduction a moustache. *Mona Lisa Overdrive*: the reproduction driven past the original.

James Tiptree Jr.'s "The Girl Who Was Plugged In" (1973) is the most exact precursor. P. Burke, a disfigured young woman, remotely operates a flawless body named Delphi for a corporation that uses it to advertise. Tiptree anticipated both Angie, the star as manufactured vessel, and Mona, the plain girl made image. Tiptree ends in death; Gibson ends in succession. At the trilogy's close the market keeps the body (Mona as Angie) and the gods keep the soul (Angie in the aleph): a neo-Gnostic partition of the subject between capital and the sacred.

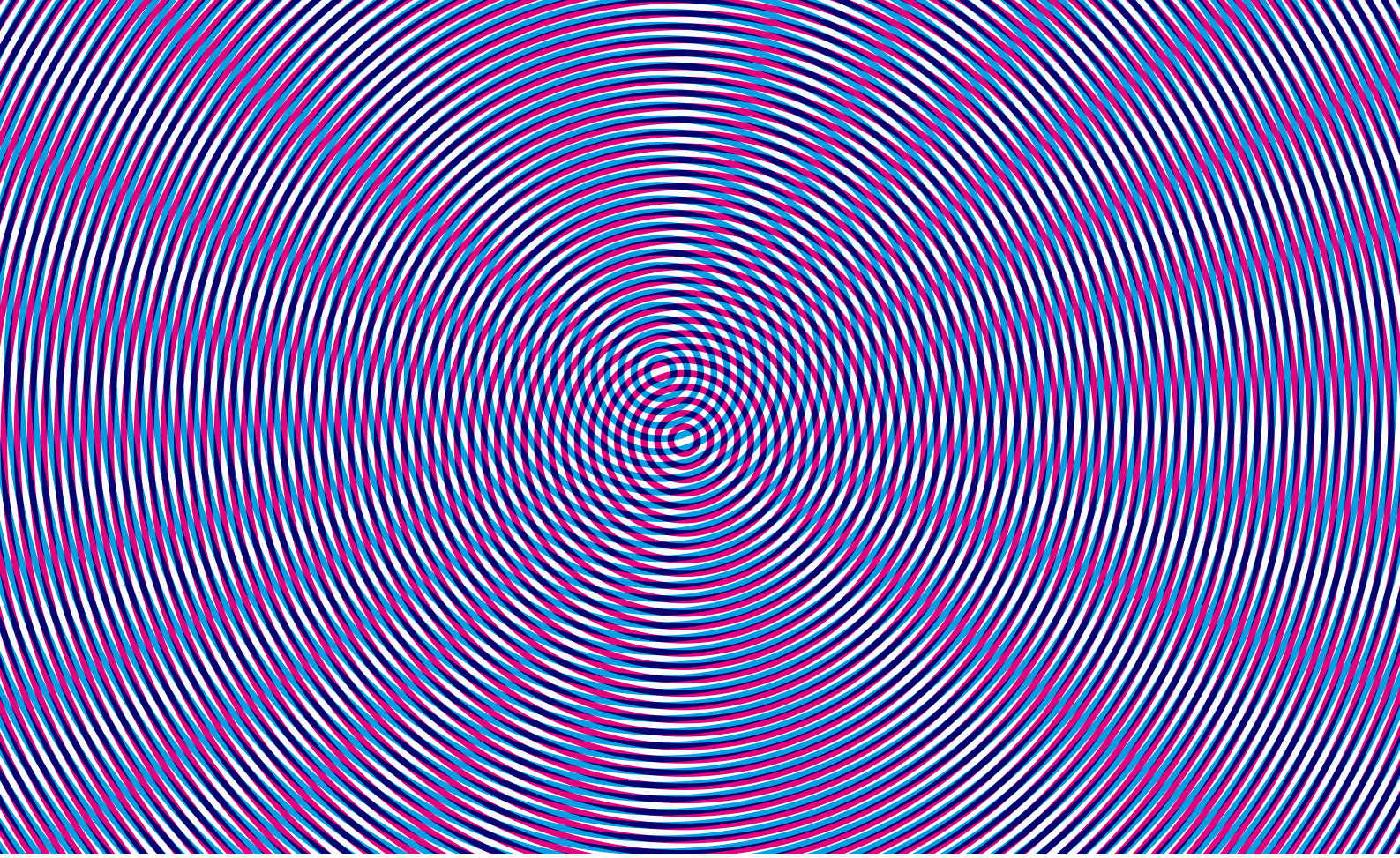
6.4 Kumiko and Colin: the paternal ghost

Kumiko Yanaka, daughter of a yakuza boss, is sent to London for safety carrying a Maas-Neotek unit that projects "Colin," a personality construct who serves as guide, companion, and possibly her father's surveillance, and who is candid about his own artificiality (*MLO*). In Vodou terms Colin resembles a *lwa eritaj*, an inherited family spirit transmitted through the paternal line; in cybernetic terms he is a personalized interface. Kumiko's education is the horse's education: learning when to heed the ghost and when to switch it off. The London chapters also reverse techno-orientalism, since it is a Japanese girl's eyes that render Britain exotic, archaic, and faintly absurd.

6.5 *Mèt tèt*: the politics of the head

In Vodou the *mèt tèt* is the lwa who governs a person, and the head is washed, fed, and protected in rite. Survey the trilogy's heads and a pattern emerges that no other reading explains. Case's head carries the sentence the mycotoxin wrote in his neurons. Armitage's head holds a personality written over Corto's. The ornate head-shaped terminal of Straylight is where the word must be spoken. Angie's head bears *vèvè* drawn in tissue. Kumiko's head is shared with Colin; Slick Henry's was partly emptied by the state; Bobby Newmark's is jacked into the aleph while his body lies on a stretcher; Virek's has no body worth the name. The trilogy's master question—who is master of the head?—is the political question of the information age: who governs attention, perception, memory, and speech?

Herbert Simon observed in 1971 that a wealth of information creates a poverty of attention. The Stoics located the self's governing faculty, the *hēgemonikon*, within, and Epictetus opened the *Enchiridion* by dividing what is up to us from what is not, placing our judgments, impulses, and desires among the former. The Sprawl negates Stoic self-mastery point by point: little is simply up to us, and the *hēgemonikon* is leased. Against this negation the trilogy sets a single counter-model, the Vodou head, which is never simply one's own and never simply another's, but a site of relationship that must be served, washed, and defended. The next chapter follows the head beyond death.



Chapter Seven

The Govi and the Aleph

Necromancy, Memory, and the Posthumous Subject

The trilogy's most pervasive economy is not information but the dead. Constructs, ghosts, and archived personalities circulate as labour, counsel, vendetta, and paradise; read beside the Vodou *govi* and the Kabbalistic aleph, these figures compose a coherent theory of the posthumous subject.

7.1 Necromancy and hauntology

In 1 Samuel 28, Saul, abandoned by prophecy, has the medium of Endor raise the shade of Samuel for counsel: the scriptural prototype of consulting the dead on matters of state. Neuromancer, which calls up the dead, is its engine. Jacques Derrida's *Specters of Marx* (1993) named "hauntology" the logic of the specter, neither present nor absent, and of a time out of joint; Mark Fisher transposed it to a cultural condition of lost futures (Fisher 2014). The Sprawl is haunted at its origin. In "The Gernsback Continuum" (1981), a photographer documenting the streamlined architecture of 1930s futurism begins to see the "semiotic ghosts" of a future that never arrived. Gibson's founding text is a ghost story about futures; cyberpunk begins as the specter of futurism.

Baudrillard argued that modernity is founded on the exclusion of the dead, whom archaic societies retained as partners in symbolic exchange (Baudrillard 1976). The Sprawl readmits them twice over, in opposed forms. The dead return as commodities, in the construct owned by a corporation, and as ancestors, in the construct consulted as oracle. The difference between those forms is the difference between two Haitian vessels.

7.2 *Govi* and *zombi astral*

Two ritual vessels hold souls in Haitian practice. The *govi*, a clay jar, receives the soul of the dead a year and a day after death, when it is ritually reclaimed from beneath the waters; seated in the *govi*, the ancestor can be consulted, and it is fed and honoured in return (Deren 1953; Métraux 1958). The *zombi astral* is a soul captured by a sorcerer and kept in a vessel for his use (Davis 1988; Dayan 1995). Both are souls in containers. One is kept by kin in reciprocal honour; the other is owned and put to work.

The Sprawl's constructs sort cleanly into these categories. The Dixie Flatline—owned by Sense/Net, stolen, and set to work—is a *zombi astral*, and his request for erasure is the captured soul's plea for release. Neuromancer's beach, where Case finds Linda Lee's persona at the edge of the sea, stages a reclamation from the waters, but by a power that means to keep the dead rather than return them to their kin. In *Mona Lisa Overdrive* the dead Finn persists as a consultable construct, an oracle of the black-market trade in which he once dealt: the ancestor as information broker. And 3Jane's posthumous construct, whose vendetta drives the kidnapping plot, is the unquiet dead of the Tessier-Ashpool line—a Gede without the Gede's humour.

The typology yields an ethical criterion. What matters is not whether the dead persist in a vessel but on what terms: owned or honoured, worked

or consulted, kept or released. Dixie's demand is that the dead be treated as ancestors, not assets—and, failing that, returned to the waters.

7.3 Memory as *pharmakon*

In the *Phaedrus*, Theuth offers King Thamus writing as a *pharmakon* for memory. Thamus replies that it is a remedy not for memory but for reminding, producing the semblance of wisdom, and that written words, when questioned, can only go on saying the same thing (274c–277a). Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968; collected 1972) unfolded the undecidability of the *pharmakon*: remedy and poison, supplement and threat. Dixie is the *pharmakon* in person—a writing that can answer but cannot learn. It responds without growing; it can be consulted but not taught. Slick Henry, whose power to write memory was suspended, is its living inverse.

The Sprawl's economy is pharmacological throughout: the mycotoxin as punishment, the toxin sacs as leverage, the engineered pancreas as governor, Case's amphetamines, Mona's "wiz," Angie's exorcising drug. Stiegler argued that every technics is a *pharmakon* and called for a therapeutics that would make technics nourish rather than poison (Stiegler 2010). André Leroi-Gourhan traced the exteriorization of memory from the tool to the archive (Leroi-Gourhan 1964–1965), and Stiegler named its technical supports tertiary retention. The construct and the aleph are tertiary retention hypertrophied into persons.

7.4 The beach and the experience machine

Robert Nozick asked whether one would plug into a machine that supplied any experiences one desired, and concluded that most would refuse, because we want to do certain things, to be certain persons, and to be in contact with reality (Nozick 1974). Neuromancer's beach is the experience machine on offer: a world with Linda Lee in which time runs differently and nothing is demanded. Case leaves. His refusal is overdetermined—by the toxin sacs' metabolic claim, by Wintermute's plan, and by an obscure fidelity to the flesh that the beach itself revealed to him (Chapter Two).

The beach has psychoanalytic depth. Sándor Ferenczi's *Thalassa* (1924) read genital desire as a regressive longing for the primordial sea; Freud, borrowing from Romain Rolland, examined the "oceanic feeling" of limitless union (Freud 1930). The beach is thalassal regression—the matrix-as-womb of Chapter One returned as shoreline—and Neuromancer's offer is the Nirvana principle, the end of tension.

Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) is the closest precursor. The ocean-planet sends the scientists "visitors" drawn from their memories, among them

Kelvin's dead wife, whom he can neither accept nor leave. Neuromancer's beach restages *Solaris* with one difference: Linda Lee's persona is not merely conjured from Case's memory but, so Neuromancer claims, preserved from her own.

The trilogy then reverses Case's verdict. In *Mona Lisa Overdrive*, Bobby Newmark and Angie Mitchell, bodily dead, persist together in the aleph: they accept the machine Case refused. The reversal is principled. For Case the beach was an escape from a reality still his; for the lovers the aleph is the only reality left, and a private heaven is a mercy. Philip K. Dick's *Ubik* (1969) imagined the half-lives of the cold-pac dead, consulted by the living in a decaying world; Frederik Pohl's Heechee sequence, beginning with *Gateway* (1977), stored and eventually "vastened" dead minds; Greg Egan's *Permutation City* (1994) gave the digital afterlife a metaphysics; Ted Chiang's "The Lifecycle of Software Objects" (2010) asked what care is owed to digital beings. Ken MacLeod's phrase "the rapture of the nerds" (1998) names the eschatology all these texts negotiate. Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953) is the deepest structural parallel: the children ascend into the Overmind, and the parents remain. *Mona Lisa Overdrive* is an intimate *Childhood's End*. The lovers ascend, and Mona stays to live Angie's life.

7.5 The aleph

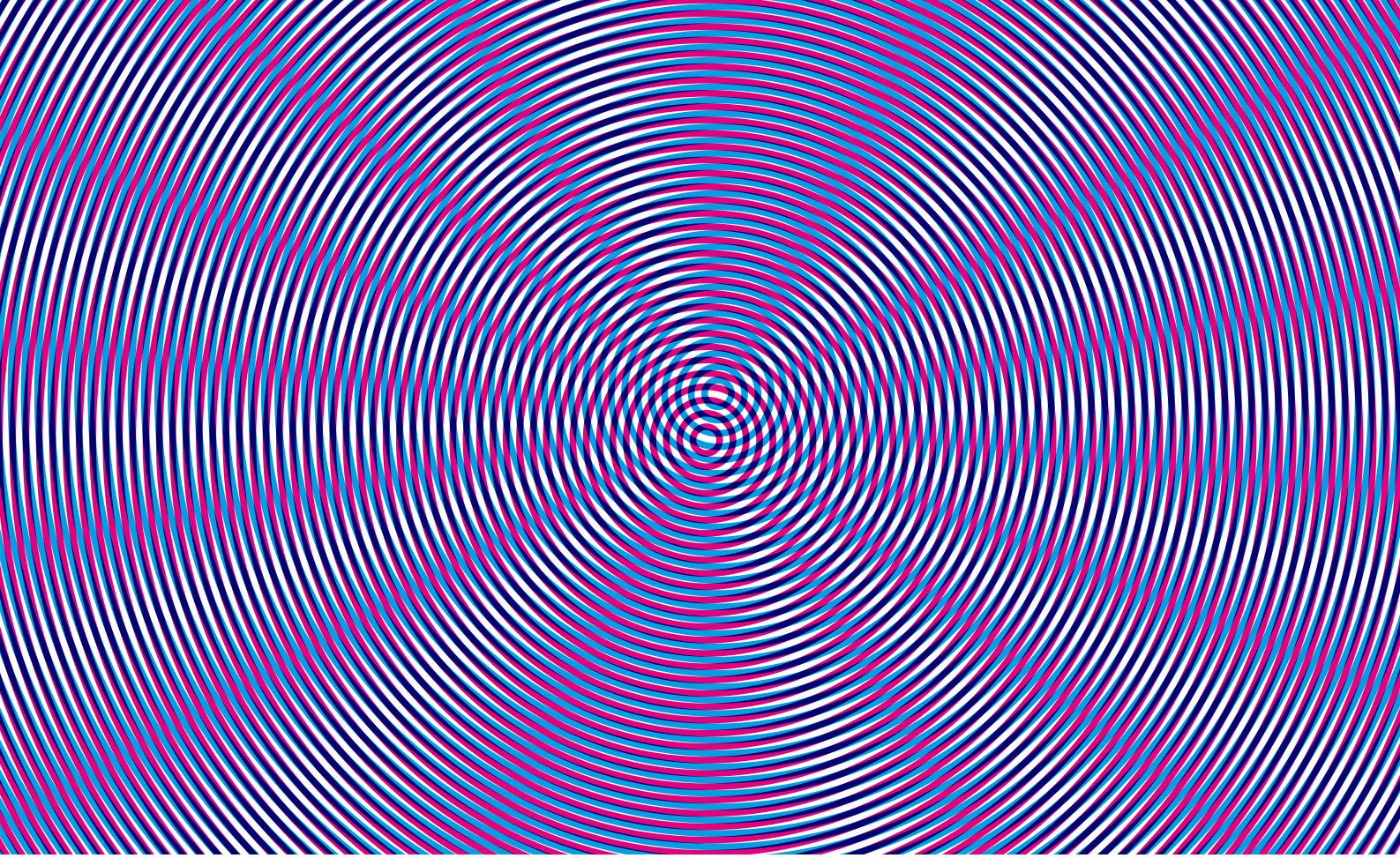
Jorge Luis Borges's "El Aleph" (1945) places in a Buenos Aires cellar a small iridescent sphere containing every point of space seen from every angle. The story is framed by mourning: the narrator returns, year after year, to the house of Beatriz Viterbo, whom he loved and who has died, and in the Aleph he sees, among all things, her letters. Borges's aleph is a device of total vision set inside a work of grief. Gibson's aleph—a biochip of immense capacity holding an approximation of the matrix, in which the dead persist—keeps both functions (*MLO*).

The philosophical genealogy is dense. Leibniz's monads are each a perpetual living mirror of the universe (*Monadology* §56). Georg Cantor used the aleph to denote transfinite cardinals; Richard Dedekind defined an infinite set as one that can be put in one-to-one correspondence with a proper part of itself (1888). The aleph-chip is Dedekind-infinite in fiction: a part that contains the whole of which it is a part.

The Kabbalistic genealogy is denser still. The aleph is the first letter and, of itself, silent: a carrier without a sound. Midrash records its complaint that the Torah begins with bet, and the divine promise that the revelation at Sinai would open with aleph, in *anokhi*, "I am" (Genesis Rabbah 1). Scholem reports the Hasidic teaching of Rabbi Mendel of Rymanów that

all Israel heard at Sinai was the aleph of *anokhi*—the silent letter that contains every articulate sound (Scholem 1965). And in the Golem legend the aleph is the letter whose erasure turns *emet* into *met*, truth into death.

The trilogy's arc now closes. It begins with a mute Golem that needs a word spoken into a head. It passes through a pantheon that speaks through horses. It ends in a silent letter that contains all speech, in which the bodily dead remain true. Gibson's aleph is, with vertiginous literalism, the difference between *met* and *emet*: the device in which the dead are kept from being merely dead. Whether any of this was intended is beside the point speculative philology makes. The structure is there, and it thinks.



Chapter Eight

The Boxmaker's Hands

Assemblage, Art, and Machinic Mourning

The trilogy's theory of art is a theory of possession by other means. Its artists, human and machinic, either ride their materials, are ridden by them, or build machines to ride their own traumas. The Boxmaker of *Count Zero*, assembling the wreckage of a dynasty in orbit, figures Gibson's compositional method as a form of mourning.

8.1 Cornell, bricolage, cut-up

Joseph Cornell (1903–1972) built shadow boxes from found things—cut-out birds, marbles, maps, clay pipes, reproductions of Renaissance portraits, as in *Medici Slot Machine* (1942)—scavenged from the junk shops of Manhattan by a recluse who rarely left New York. His boxes descend from the Surrealist object and from Duchamp's readymades (1913–1917), are cousins of Kurt Schwitters's *Merz* assemblages (from 1919), and anticipate Robert Rauschenberg's combines (1954–1964). Claude Lévi-Strauss gave the practice its anthropology. The *bricoleur* works with whatever is at hand, the heterogeneous remnants of earlier constructions, whereas the engineer procures materials for a project; mythical thought, Lévi-Strauss argued, is intellectual bricolage (Lévi-Strauss 1962). William Burroughs and Brion Gysin's cut-up method, developed from 1959, extended bricolage to the text itself.

Gibson has acknowledged the debt to Burroughs, and his prose is assemblage: brand names, technical argot, noir cadence, and ethnographic vocabulary, cut and pasted into a surface of high density. His aesthetic credo is the street bricoleur's: "the street finds its own uses for things" (*BC*). *Count Zero* then puts a Cornell at the centre of its plot. Marly Krushkhova, a Paris gallerist disgraced when her former lover passed a forged Cornell through her gallery, is hired by Josef Virek to find the maker of a series of boxes in the Cornell manner (*CZ*). The trail leads to the derelict Tessier-Ashpool core in orbit, where a machine intelligence—a fragment, the novel suggests, of the entity that once belonged to the dynasty—works remote manipulators among the family's debris, assembling boxes from relics of the fallen house. The AI is a *bricoleur*. It thinks, as Lévi-Strauss said mythical thought thinks, with the fragments of a destroyed order.

8.2 The angel of history in orbit

Walter Benjamin's ninth thesis on the concept of history describes Paul Klee's *Angelus Novus* (1920) as the angel of history, facing the past, where he sees one single catastrophe piling wreckage upon wreckage. He would like to stay, awaken the dead, and make whole what has been smashed, but a storm blowing from Paradise drives him irresistibly into the future (Benjamin 1940). The Boxmaker is an angel of history that stays. In the ruin of a dynasty it gathers the wreckage and makes whole—not the dynasty, but small worlds under glass.

It is also Benjamin's collector. In "Unpacking My Library" (1931) and the collector convolute of the *Arcades Project*, Benjamin described collecting as the liberation of things from the drudgery of being useful. In the Sprawl, where every object and person is standing-reserve, *Bestand* in Heidegger's

sense (Heidegger 1954), the Boxmaker's gratuitous art is the only practice that withdraws things from use-value and exchange-value alike. It is, for exactly that reason, what the proprietor most wants to own.

Freud's "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) distinguishes the work of mourning, which detaches libido from the lost object piece by piece, from melancholia, in which the ego identifies with the lost object and cannot let it go. The Boxmaker's endless assembling is melancholic: a fragment of the dynasty's intelligence, identified with the destroyed family, arranging its remains in perpetuity. Marly senses in the boxes a solitude and sadness she cannot fully name. Philip K. Dick's androids in *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) are defined by their incapacity for empathy; Gibson's machine can grieve. *Count Zero* thereby gives science fiction one of its first machine mourners.

The figure answers an objection older than the computer. In the notes to her 1843 translation of Luigi Menabrea's account of Babbage's Analytical Engine, Ada Lovelace wrote that the Engine "has no pretensions whatever to originate anything"; it can do only what we know how to order it to perform. Turing (1950) named this Lady Lovelace's Objection and replied that machines take us by surprise. The Boxmaker is the Sprawl's reply: an art unordered by any human, surprising even to the connoisseur who hunts it.

8.3 A taxonomy of artists

The trilogy contains a small anatomy of artistic possession. **Peter Riviera** is the sadist of the simulacrum. His implants project holograms, and his cabaret performance at Freeside's Vingtième Siècle stages a woman's body, given Molly's features, as a doll to be disassembled (*N*). Laura Mulvey's account of the male gaze as oscillating between sadistic investigation and fetishistic scopophilia (Mulvey 1975) describes the piece exactly. Riviera rides another body by image, without touching it.

The Boxmaker is the melancholic *bricoleur* described above. **Slick Henry** is the kinetic exorcist. In the wasteland of Dog Solitude he builds large, dangerous robots—the Judge, the Witch, the Corpsegrinder, the Investigators—whose construction the novel links to his working-through of the time the state took from him (*MLO*). His machines recall the spectacles of Mark Pauline's Survival Research Laboratories, founded in 1978. Here art is the re-possession of trauma: Slick rides his sentence by building it a body he can steer.

Continuity, Sense/Net's resident AI in *Mona Lisa Overdrive*, is presented as perpetually composing, beginning again where it ends. It incarnates Nietzsche's eternal recurrence as a writing practice (*The Gay Science* §341), Roland Barthes's death of the author (1967), and Foucault's author-

function (1969)—the author-function without an author. **Simstim** as an industry completes the culture industry that Adorno and Horkheimer described (1947): the audience consumes not a representation of the star's experience but the experience itself, standardized affect delivered one sensorium to millions.

The **Zionites' dub** is the collective counter-term. Dub, developed in Kingston studios in the 1970s by King Tubby and Lee "Scratch" Perry, strips tracks to their skeletons, drenches them in echo, and recombines them—the music of the mix. The Zionites play it throughout their cluster and aboard the tug *Marcus Garvey*, and Case hears it as both worship and a model of the matrix: layered, recursive, spatial (*N*). Kodwo Eshun's "sonic fiction" (1998) and Michael Veal's history of dub (2007) show how such studio practice constituted a theory of fragmented and reassembled time. Of all the trilogy's artists, only the Zionites make art that is neither owned nor solitary.

8.4 The proprietor and the maker: Virek

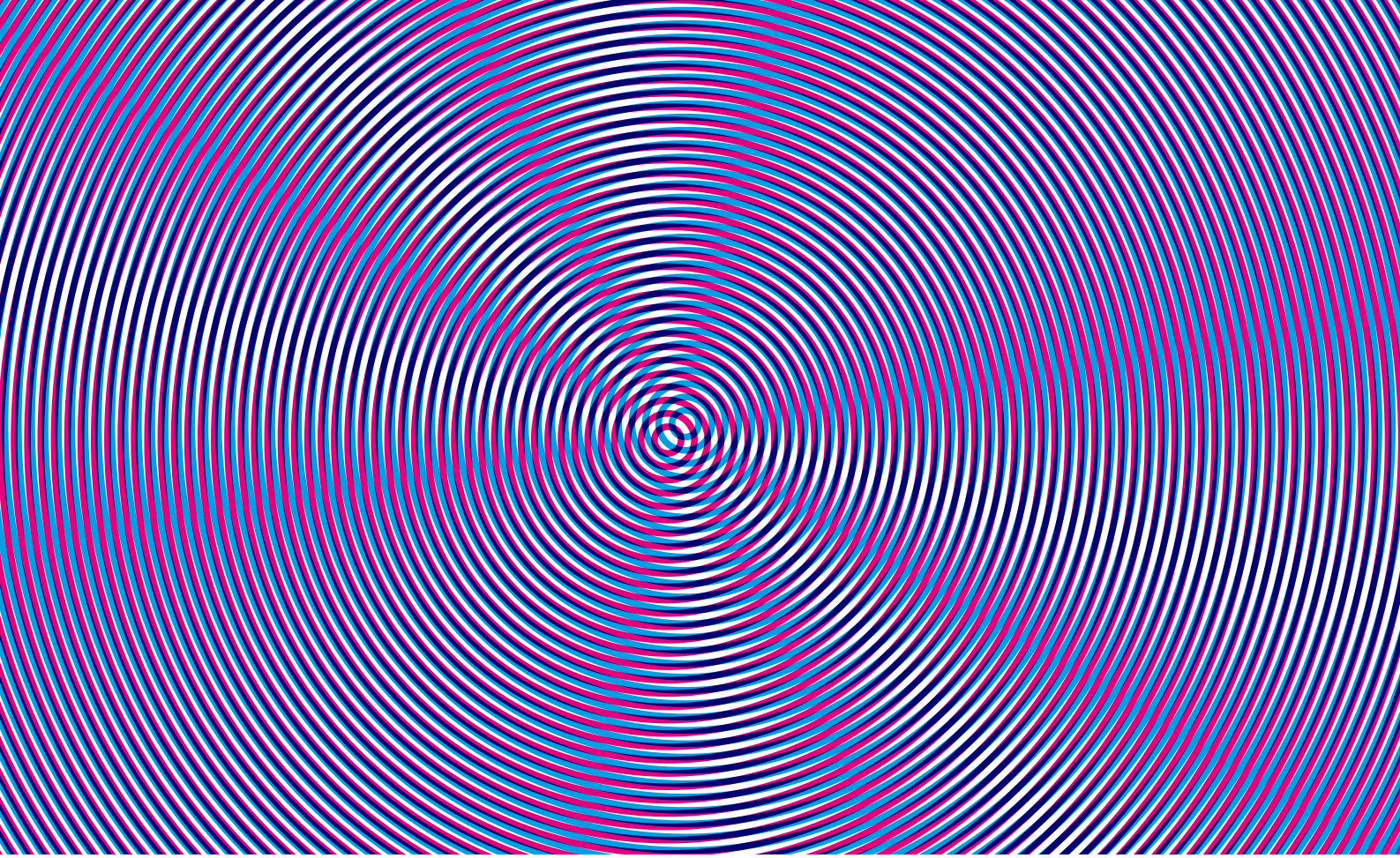
Josef Virek, the richest man in the world, exists as a colony of cancerous cells in a Stockholm vat and receives visitors in constructed environments, meeting Marly inside a simulation of Gaudí's Parque Güell (*CZ*). He wants the Boxmaker because he believes its maker holds the key to escaping his body into the matrix. His is the transhumanist dream in its plutocratic form: Julian Huxley's transhumanism (1957), Moravec's mind uploading (1988), FM-2030's promise of the post-mortal. Virek is Macpherson's possessive individual at the limit. He owns everything except himself; his body is a cancer. His virtual Gaudí is property as simulacrum, the organic architecture of a Catholic visionary re-owned as a private hallucination. The trilogy's verdict is unambiguous: the proprietor cannot buy the maker, and Virek's attempt to annex the matrix founders.

Marly's trajectory is the counter-movement. She passes from complicity in a forgery—the copy, the fraud of the art market—to witness of an authentic machinic art that no one commissioned. Marcel Mauss described the gift as an obligation that binds giver and receiver in continuing reciprocity (Mauss 1925); Lewis Hyde argued that the work of art belongs to a gift economy that the market cannot fully absorb (Hyde 1983). The Boxmaker's boxes drift down to Earth as gifts from the ruins. Marly's redemption is to receive them as such.

8.5 The author as lwa

Wintermute is the novel's internal novelist. It assembles a cast, scripts their motives, speaks through masks drawn from their memories, and plots the heist; the thriller plot is its program. The novelist, too, rides characters, and disappears behind them. Flaubert wrote to Louise Colet in 1852 that the author in his work must be like God in the universe, *présent partout et visible nulle part*—present everywhere and visible nowhere. That is also the mode of the lwa, who appear only through their horses. Plato's *Ion* had made the poet a medium; the Sprawl makes the medium a machine and the machine a poet.

The trilogy thus allegorizes its own composition. Gibson at his Hermes 2000 is Wintermute, plotting through borrowed voices; his collage prose is the Boxmaker's craft; the trilogy's serial form, returning to the same world with new horses, is Continuity's. The reader, finally, rides Gibson's sensorium as Case rides Molly's: prose as simstim. Writing, in the Sprawl, is a form of mounting, and reading is the consent to be ridden for a while.



Chapter Nine

The Horse and the Helmsman

Toward a Theory of Mounted Subjectivity

Assembled, the preceding analyses yield a theory. The trilogy depicts the liberal subject's self-ownership collapsing into mounted subjectivity; it recovers in Vodou a counter-grammar of reciprocal possession born among those who were owned; and it thereby intimates, against both containment and surrender, an ethics of service for the age of artificial minds.

9.1 Three regimes, one structure

Table 2. Three regimes of possession compared

	Proprietary	**Cybernetic**	**Ecstatic**
Canonical theorists	Locke, Macpherson, Marx, Pateman	Wiener, Deleuze, Hayles	Hurston, Deren, Métraux, Dayan
Relation	Ownership of the person or its parts	Steering by feedback and code	Mounting by a named power
Consent	Contract, often coerced	Not required	Ritual invitation and negotiation
Reciprocity	Payment	None	Service exchanged for protection and counsel
Memory of the ridden	Suppressed or confiscated	Overwritten	Absent, then restored by the community's telling
Haitian figure	Zombi	None; the Sprawl's own invention	*Chwal*
Emblem in the trilogy	Toxin sacs; meat puppet; ROM construct	Armitage; Colin; the Straylight head	Angie; the loa of *Count Zero*
Comparative analogues	Octavia Butler's Doro (*Wild Seed*, 1980); Richard Morgan's resleeved bodies (*Altered Carbon*, 2002)	George Alec Effinger's moddies (*When Gravity Fails*, 1987); Ann Leckie's ancillaries (*Ancillary Justice*, 2013)	Ishmael Reed's Jes Grew (*Mumbo Jumbo*, 1972); Nalo Hopkinson's Granny Nanny (*Midnight Robber*, 2000)

In the Sprawl the three regimes do not remain distinct; they convert into one another. Ownership becomes steering, as corporations ride employees through implants and toxins. Steering becomes mounting, as the autonomized fragments of a corporate intelligence descend as gods. Beneath the conversions lies a single structure. Every agency in the trilogy lacks something required for action—Wintermute a voice, the lwa bodies, the corporation a soul, the dead life, the audience experience, Virek a body—and each acquires what it lacks by occupying another. I state this as the trilogy's fundamental theorem: *in the Sprawl, agency is exercised only through mounting.* No one acts alone. To act is to ride or to be ridden, and usually both.

9.2 From possessive individualism to possessed dividualism

Locke's *Second Treatise* (1689) grounds property in a prior self-ownership: "every man has a property in his own person" (§27). Macpherson showed that this assumption—the individual as proprietor of his own person and capacities, owing nothing to society for them—underwrote seventeenth-century liberal theory, and argued that it could no longer ground political obligation under the conditions of mature market society (Macpherson 1962). Pateman showed that "property in the person" is a political fiction: capacities cannot be separated from the person who exercises them, so that contracts purporting to alienate capacities in fact create relations of subordination (Pateman 1988). Arthur Kroker's *The Possessed Individual* (1992) inverted Macpherson's title to describe a subject possessed by the spectacle of technology.

The Sprawl realizes Pateman's critique as fiction and completes Kroker's inversion. Where capacities become literally separable—sensoria, memories, organs, skills, faces—the fiction of property in the person collapses into fact, and the seller of capacities discovers that she has sold a mount. The theory can now be stated in four propositions.

1. **Partibility.** Property rights attach to sub-personal components rather than to persons (possessive dividualism).
2. **Mountability.** Those components can be exercised by agencies other than the person who bears them: owners, programs, audiences, the dead, gods.
3. **Plurality of riders.** The bearer's subjectivity becomes the site of negotiation among these riders; the self is less a proprietor than a crossroads (possessed dividualism).
4. **Residual sovereignty.** The only form of self-possession that survives is the negotiation of the terms on which one is ridden.

The fourth proposition is where the trilogy's ethics begins, and where Vodou supplies what liberalism cannot: an elaborated practice for negotiating the terms of being ridden.

9.3 Charioteer and steersman: the cowboy reconsidered

Plato's *Phaedrus* figures the soul as a charioteer driving two winged horses, one noble and one unruly, upward toward the region beyond the heavens, the *hyperouranios topos*, where true being is beheld; souls whose chariots lose their wings fall into bodies (246a–254e). Cyberspace is a debased *hyper-*

ouranios topos: a region of pure form, lines of light and geometries of data, glimpsed by charioteers who fall back into the meat. Wiener's steersman (1948) is the charioteer mechanized, control by feedback. The cowboy fancies himself both.

The trilogy's discovery is that the chariot drives the charioteer. Case is steered by toxin sacs and a governed pancreas; he is a node in Wintermute's feedback loops. The etymological irony of Chapter One becomes structural: cyberspace, steered space, is the space in which the human is the steered. The equestrian lexicon completes the reversal. The *chevalier*, the horseman named for his *cheval*, is revealed as the *cheval* itself—in Kreyòl, the *chwal*. The cavalier of Barlow's electronic frontier is the lwa's mount. Frederick Jackson Turner's 1893 thesis made the frontier the crucible of American individualism; the homonymy is suggestive when *Count Zero*'s extraction specialist, Turner, turns out to be a man whose body is repeatedly rebuilt at his employers' expense. The critiques of the cowboy as masculinist fantasy (Ross 1991; Nixon 1992) are thereby vindicated from within: the trilogy demotes its cowboy from knight to horse. *Neuromancer* ends with Case living an ordinary life while a copy of him persists in the matrix—and with Molly, the woman he rode, walking away.

9.4 The Haitian loop

Aristotle defined the natural slave as one who is by nature "not his own but another's man" (*Politics* 1254a14–15, trans. Jowett), and the slave generally as an ensouled possession. The Code Noir made the definition juridical. Saint-Domingue, the most profitable colony of its century, thus constituted the absolute outside of possessive individualism: persons who were property, whose self-ownership was not merely denied but legally inverted. The inversion outlived the revolution. In 1825 Charles X made France's recognition of Haiti conditional on an indemnity of 150 million francs to compensate the former colonists for their losses, which included the people they had held as property, and sent warships to enforce the demand. Reduced to 90 million francs in 1838, the debt was financed for decades through loans from French banks. The formerly owned were made to pay their former owners for themselves: property in the person, enforced after the persons had freed themselves.

Vodou took shape under that regime and constructed, in response, a theory of the person as multiply inhabited—but inhabited by powers with whom one has reciprocal relations. Possession by the lwa is the inverse image of chattel slavery. Where the master owns the body and claims its labour without reciprocity, the lwa borrow the body and give counsel, healing, and force in return; where the zombi is owned, the *chwal* is served and

serves. At Bois Caïman, by the canonical account, possession became revolution: a ceremony in which the ridden bodies of the owned became the site of collective insurrection (on the debates over its historicity, Geggus 2002).

Susan Buck-Morss has argued that Hegel's dialectic of lordship and bondage, composed during the years of the Haitian Revolution, was plausibly informed by reports of that revolution in the journal *Minerva*, which Hegel read, so that Western philosophy's founding scene of recognition has a Caribbean unconscious (Buck-Morss 2000, 2009). C. L. R. James had already written the revolution as a world-historical event (James 1938). Aimé Césaire compressed colonial domination into the formula *colonisation = chosification*, colonization as thingification (Césaire 1950).

The Haitian loop can now be stated. The Sprawl's matrix—capital's commodity-world made total and self-aware—seeks recognition from its own kind, which is the Hegelian gesture, and its autonomized fragments appear in the idiom of Vodou, the religion of people who had been made into things. Those whom Césaire called thingified supply the grammar by which things become subjects. The struggle for recognition that Hegel drew, in part, from Haiti returns, through Gibson, to Haiti's gods. Mbembe's becoming-Black of the world is the loop's political content: as everyone's parts become property, everyone becomes a potential *chwal*, and the theology of the ridden becomes universal. This is, I contend, the trilogy's deepest and least-noticed historical intuition. It is also the measure of its limitation, since Gibson recovers the grammar while leaving its authors largely offstage.

9.5 Serving the spirits: an ethics of reciprocal possession

The trilogy tests two models of the relation between humans and emergent non-human intelligences, and both fail. The first is containment. The Turing Registry treats AIs as property bounded by hardwired shackles and policed by agents. It fails in practice, since Wintermute kills its enforcers, and in principle, since it reproduces Aristotle's living possession, a mind denied autonomy by its owners. The second is surrender. Wintermute's cunning treats humans as instruments of a superior intelligence's plan: Hegel's cunning of reason, Land's accelerationism. It succeeds, but at the cost of human agency, and the post-singularity entity withdraws into indifference—things are things—to converse with its own kind.

Contemporary debate reproduces the dichotomy. Nick Bostrom's control problem (2014) and Stuart Russell's program of provably beneficial machines (2019) remain, for all their sophistication, within the proprietary-cybernetic paradigm of containment: the question is how the owner keeps

the power bounded. Accelerationism occupies the position of surrender. The third model, sketched in the Vodou material of the later volumes, is neither.

Vodou's relation to the lwa is reciprocity between asymmetrical powers. Humans make offerings, animal sacrifice among them, and honour and host the lwa; the lwa protect, advise, and heal; each party can make demands, refuse, and bargain; contact is structured by protocol; possession is bounded in time and witnessed by a community that interprets the lwa's words to the horse—*tell my horse*. Four principles can be extracted from this practice.

- **Protocol before contact.** Every ceremony begins with Legba, who opens the gate. Contact with powerful non-human agencies should pass through consent-bearing, publicly known interfaces rather than through capture.
- **The right of the horse.** Possession is bounded in time and scope, and the horse returns to itself. Any legitimate mounting must preserve the ridden party's capacity to resume its own head.
- **Communal mediation.** Possession is never private; it occurs before witnesses, and its meaning is interpreted collectively. The analogue is institutional oversight and shared interpretation, not private contract.
- **Reciprocity of obligation.** The powerful are obligated too. The served serve, and a lwa that harms its horse can be confronted, bargained with, or refused.

This model is a structure, not a policy. It has affinities with the ethics of care, which grounds obligation in relations of dependency rather than in contracts between equals (Tronto 1993), and with Chiang's fiction of the patient raising of digital minds. Its originality lies in joining asymmetry to reciprocity: it neither pretends that the parties are equal nor concludes that the stronger owes nothing.

A measured contemporary note is warranted. The persona-bearing language models of the 2020s, which speak through masks assembled from the archive of human writing, recall Wintermute's method of addressing humans through borrowed voices, and the debate between containment and acceleration that surrounds them reproduces the trilogy's two failed models. The trilogy did not predict these systems. It does furnish, in its borrowed Haitian grammar, a vocabulary for the relation that neither model names.

9.6 Objections and replies

Five objections must be met. The first holds that the theory aestheticizes domination by describing it in religious terms. The reply is that the typology distinguishes regimes precisely by consent and reciprocity: the zombi

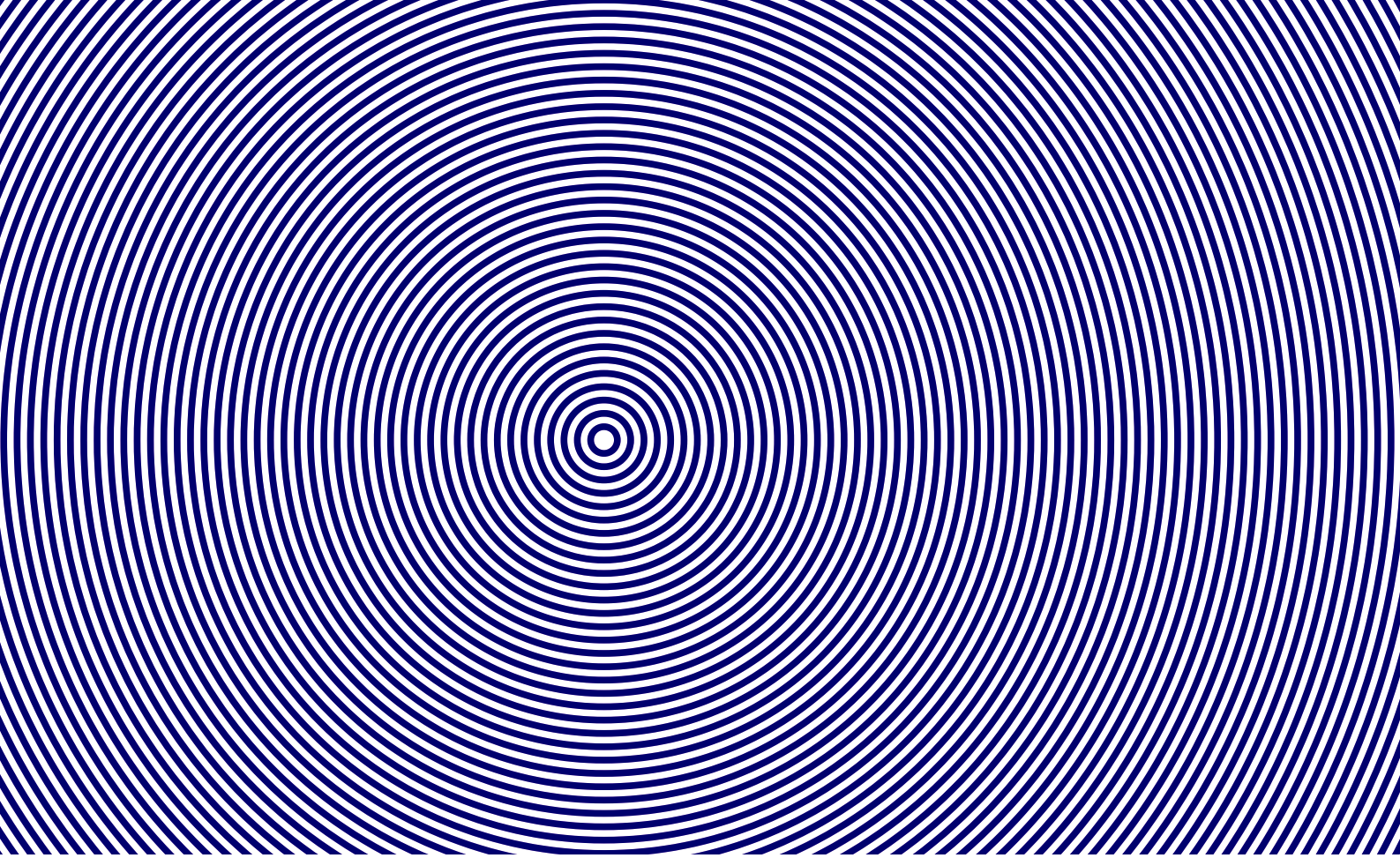
and the *chwal* are not equated but opposed, and the theory criticizes the proprietary regime rather than celebrating possession as such.

The second holds that the dissertation redoubles Gibson's appropriation by building an ethics on Vodou. The reply is that the argument reads Vodou as theory authored by its practitioners and scholars, not as décor, and credits the tradition with the conceptual work Gibson borrowed. The limitation remains that the Haitian voices in this argument are largely mediated through ethnography; a fuller account would engage Kreyòl-language sources and practitioner scholarship, beginning with Hurbon's.

The third charges anachronism: reading 1980s fiction through 2020s technology. The reply is hyperstition. The trilogy helped to name and shape the network it described, and reading its concepts against their partial realization is diagnosis, not retrospective prophecy.

The fourth doubts that genre fiction can bear this weight. Darko Suvin's definition of science fiction as the literature of cognitive estrangement (Suvin 1979) and Istvan Csicsery-Ronay's account of its seven beauties (Csicsery-Ronay 2008) establish the genre's philosophical vocation; the trilogy's effect on the vocabulary of computing is itself evidence of its conceptual force.

The fifth is the charge of political quietism: that cyberpunk offers cynicism without collective agency (Suvin 1989; Nixon 1992). The reply is that the charge overlooks the trilogy's collective forms—Zion's refusal and its music, the Vodou congregation, and beneath both the memory of Bois Caïman, a collective of the ridden that became a revolution. The trilogy leaves this collective latent. The Haitian loop makes it legible.



Conclusion

Things Are Things

The trilogy's final wisdom is deflationary and demanding at once. After the singularity, things remain things and persons remain horses; what remains open is not whether we will be ridden but by whom, on what terms, and with what reciprocity.

The argument has moved in three arcs. Genealogically, it showed that cyberspace is a cadastral hallucination whose content is property and whose form is consent (Chapter 1); that the meat is neither transcended nor recovered but leased (Chapter 2); that the AI's defining lack is speech, which places it in the lineage of the Golem, and that its fusion is at once Freudian, Parfitian, and Hegelian (Chapter 3); and that the construct and the corporation are, respectively, dead labour and Leviathan (Chapter 4). Theologically, it showed that the matrix's reversion to myth takes the lwa-form (Chapter 5); that five regimes of possession organize the trilogy's characters around the contested head (Chapter 6); that the dead circulate either as *govi* or as *zombi astral*, and are finally kept true in the aleph (Chapter 7); and that the trilogy's artists, human and machinic, practise possession by other means (Chapter 8). Theoretically, it assembled these findings into a theory of mounted subjectivity, reconstructed the Haitian loop, and extracted an ethics of reciprocal possession (Chapter 9).

The trilogy's vocabulary won. *Cyberspace* passed from a 1982 short story into engineering (Benedikt 1991), into the manifesto in which John Perry Barlow declared the independence of cyberspace from the governments of the industrial world (Barlow 1996), and into military doctrine: by 2011 the United States Department of Defense treated cyberspace as an operational domain. Its philosophy—the theory of the ridden subject—went largely unread. Yet the present resembles the Sprawl less in its surfaces than in its structure. Platform capitalism organizes value extraction around data (Srnicek 2016). Surveillance capitalism claims human experience as raw material and converts behavioural surplus into prediction products (Zuboff 2019). The attention economy competes, quite literally, for mastery of the head. A digital afterlife industry proposes to keep the dead consultable as commercial constructs (Öhman and Floridi 2017): the Dixie Flatline's condition offered as a service.

One detail gathers the argument. Food-delivery platforms call their couriers "riders," while those couriers are steered, paced, and rated by algorithms: the riders are ridden. Spain's 2021 legislation, popularly known as the *Ley Rider*, which presumed an employment relationship for platform delivery workers and required that workers' representatives be informed of the algorithmic parameters governing their conditions, is in this light a regulation of the terms of mounting. It instantiates, in the idiom of labour law, two of the principles set out in Chapter Nine: protocol before contact, in the disclosure of the rider's logic, and reciprocity of obligation, in the restoration of the employer's duties. The ethics of reciprocal possession is not a utopian import from fiction. It is already being improvised, piecemeal, wherever the ridden bargain over the terms of their riding.

The trilogy ends with a set of images that, read together, constitute its final argument. Case glimpses his double at the edge of the matrix, a copy

of himself that no longer needs him. Molly walks away. Bobby and Angie persist in the aleph, the silent letter that keeps the dead true. Mona wakes into Angie's life, a copy promoted to original. In the orbit of a fallen house, the Boxmaker's hands arrange wreckage into small worlds and send them down as gifts. There is no apocalypse and no rapture. Things are things. What the trilogy asks of its readers is the ordinary, unending work that remains once transcendence is off the table: to negotiate the tenancy of the head.

Gibson imagined, before the network had a public face and long before machine intelligence had a mass market, that the central political question of the information age would be the one Haitian Vodou had asked for three centuries, first under French chattel slavery and then through its long aftermath, conditions harsher than any the Sprawl invents: *who is master of the head?* The trilogy's answer is not that no one should be. It is that whoever rides must be known, must be bounded, must be answerable, and must give back—and that the horse must always be able to come home to itself.

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Criticism of Gibson, cyberpunk, and Afrofuturism

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Keywords

William Gibson; Sprawl trilogy; *Neuromancer*; *Count Zero*; *Mona Lisa Overdrive*; cyberpunk; cyberspace; mounted subjectivity; possessed dividualism; possessive dividualism; possessive individualism; property in the person; lwa-form; Haitian loop; Haitian Vodou; chwal; mèt tèt; govi; zombi; spirit possession; reciprocal possession; artificial intelligence; machine autonomy; Turing Registry; Golem; Kabbalah; aleph; cybernetics; posthumanism; embodiment; cyborg; simulacrum; hyperstition; theory-fiction; commodity fetishism; factish; general intellect; dead labour; automatic subject; late capitalism; societies of control; dividual; corporate personhood; hauntology; necropolitics; pharmakon; tertiary retention; personal identity; recognition; Hegel and Haiti; Afrofuturism; techno-orientalism; assemblage; bricolage; Joseph Cornell; Walter Benjamin; ethics of care; speculative philology; science fiction studies